

Preliminary findings from an evaluation of
the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Qikiqtaaluk, Nunavut:
Technical Report



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Key Terms and Acronyms

Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) – A quasi-judicial body that resolves complaints of discrimination under the Canadian Human Rights Act.

Canadian Human Rights Act (CHRA) – Federal legislation that protects individuals from discrimination by federal departments and agencies.

Consumer Price Index (CPI) – A measure of the average change over time in the prices paid by consumers for goods and services. In this report, we use CPI to refer to the Canadian Consumer Price Index for food purchased from stores, which tracks changes in the cost of a basket of food products over time.

Country foods – The traditional foods of the Inuit people that are collected through hunting, fishing, and harvesting.

Food insecurity – Conditions in which people experience reduced food intake or disrupted eating patterns, compromised food quality or quantity, concern about running out of food, or limited food selection due to finances or other factors affecting the availability, accessibility, quality, and use of food.

Food security – Conditions in which people have consistent physical, social, and economic access to sufficient, safe, and nutritious food which meets their dietary needs and food preferences for an active and healthy life. Food security considers the availability, accessibility, quality, and use of food, as well as the ability to obtain food in socially acceptable ways that preserve dignity.

Grocery supports – Financial assistance, provided to help families purchase groceries for children, through individual requests to the Inuit Child First Initiative or Jordan's Principle.

Group request – A funding request submitted to ICFI or Jordan's Principle to address shared the needs of multiple Inuit or First Nations children through community programs or services.

Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator – Local staff responsible for administering the Hamlet Food Voucher program, funded through the Inuit Child First Initiative, in a specific hamlet.

Hamlet Food Voucher program – Community level programs, funded through group requests to the Inuit Child First Initiative, which provided financial assistance to help families purchase groceries for Inuit children from 0-19 years old.

Indigenous Services Canada (ISC) – The federal department responsible for services for First Nations, Inuit, and Métis people, including Jordan's Principle and the Inuit Child First Initiative.

Individual request – A funding request, submitted to the Inuit Child First Initiative or Jordan’s Principle, for services, supports, or equipment to meet the unique needs of a specific First Nations or Inuit child.

Inflation – The rate at which prices for goods and services rise. High inflation means prices are climbing rapidly; lower inflation means prices are increasing, but more slowly. A decrease in prices is referred to as deflation.

Inuit Nunangat Food Security Strategy (INFSS) – A strategy developed by Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami to address food insecurity and support food sovereignty among Inuit communities.

Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI) – A temporary measure, parallel to Jordan’s Principle, intended to ensure that Inuit children have timely access to essential supports and services while an Inuit-specific framework is being developed.

Jordan’s Principle – A human rights principle established by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) to make sure that First Nations children do not face gaps, delays, or denials in accessing government services because of their identity as First Nations children.

Nutrition North Canada (NNC) – A federal program that provides direct payments to retailers to subsidize the cost of food in remote northern communities.

Nunavut Tunngavik Inc. (NTI) – The Inuit land claims organization that coordinates and manages Inuit responsibilities set out in the Nunavut Agreement and ensures that the federal and territorial governments fulfill their obligations.

Price index – A statistical measure that examines the weighted average of prices of a basket of goods and services over time.

Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB) – A measurement tool used to calculate the cost of a nutritious diet in Northern communities.

Senior Administrative Officer (SAO) office – Local municipal office responsible for managing administrative functions, including (in most cases) the Hamlet Food Voucher program.

Substantive equality – A legal principle that considers historical and systemic disadvantage to achieve equity in *outcomes*, not just equal access to services and supports.

Executive Summary

The Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI) was launched in 2018, by the Canadian government, as a temporary measure to help Inuit children access essential services “while an Inuit-specific framework is being developed.”¹ Administered by Indigenous Services Canada (ISC), the ICFI parallels Jordan’s Principle, “a human rights principle established by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) to make sure that First Nations children do not face gaps, delays, or denials in accessing government services because of their identity as First Nations children.”²

In Nunavut, by 2022, the cost of a basket of popular food items was twice the average cost in the rest of Canada, and 79% of Inuit children (ages 1-14) experienced food insecurity.³ Accordingly, support in accessing food has been the most common request to ICFI from Nunavut. Initially, each family had to make an individual request and submit individual documentation to justify their requests. As the number of individual requests grew, an administrative backlog developed at ISC, and families often faced weeks - or months - long delays before receiving supports.⁴

To more efficiently meet the needs of Inuit children, Nunavut hamlets (communities) began to request - and receive - ICFI funding to provide nutrition supports for all Inuit children in the community. The first of these Hamlet Food Voucher programs began in July of 2023. By December 2024, all but one community in Nunavut had implemented a program. Hamlet Food Voucher programs provided \$500 per child for groceries and an additional \$250 for diapers, formula, and other supplies for children under four years old.⁵

On March 31, 2025, funding for the Hamlet Food Voucher program was discontinued. ICFI returned to a system in which individual families must make requests for grocery supports. In addition, families must navigate new administrative barriers when submitting individual requests. Only some requests that link the need for grocery supports directly to a specific medical issue are being approved; all other requests are either directly denied or have delayed decisions because they are “escalated” to the national office for further review.

Evaluating the Hamlet Food Voucher program

In this report, we present preliminary findings from a multidisciplinary, mixed methods study that started as an evaluation of individual requests for grocery supports in Qikiqtaaluk and evolved as the Hamlet Food Voucher programs came into place and were then discontinued. The study, which is led by Qupanuaq and funded by Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated (NTI) and the Arctic Children and Youth Foundation, brings together researchers from Qupanuaq, the University of Colorado (Boulder), Toronto Metropolitan University, the University of Manitoba, Wilfrid Laurier University, and the University of Toronto. It is guided and supported by a Nunavut advisory committee.

We draw on key informant interviews with 21 people living/working in seven hamlets or working at the regional level (Qikiqtaaluk or Nunavut). Key informants included:

- Service coordinators, who help families access supports through ICFI;
- Service providers, such as health professionals or social workers;
- Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators and other Senior Administrative Officer (SAO) staff involved with the Hamlet Food Voucher programs;
- Grocery store managers/employees who helped administer ICFI funding at the retail level; and
- Staff members in the Indigenous Services Canada (ISC) regional office responsible for administering the ICFI in Nunavut.

We also included an analysis of data on purchases, made between the beginning of 2022 and the end of 2024, by families in the Qikiqtaaluk region of Nunavut who received ICFI grocery supports. Receipts of purchases made by families receiving grocery supports were collected, anonymized, and shared with us by ISC. These data included both grocery prices and the items purchased using individual grocery supports. Because some children continued to receive grocery supports even after implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, these data allowed us to compare prices before and after program implementation in several hamlets.

Preliminary findings

We present our preliminary findings in four chapters of this technical report. Each of these chapters is briefly described below; click on the hyperlinks to read our findings in more detail.

In **Chapter 1**, we draw on existing literature to briefly describe food insecurity in the Qikiqtaaluk region of Nunavut as a long-term, systemic problem. It is grounded in colonialism and compounded by a gap between the support available through government benefits (like income assistance and child benefits) and the cost of living in Nunavut. We also draw on key informant interviews and Jordan's Principle and ICFI policy documents to describe the trajectory of the ICFI approach to supporting food security in Nunavut. We find that the Hamlet Food Voucher programs, which took a universal approach to food security for Inuit children, offered an efficient means of extending food security support to Inuit children; they eliminated the burdens of submitting and processing individual requests for grocery supports. Funding for the Hamlet Food Voucher programs was discontinued in April 2025, and significant new barriers to receiving individual grocery support were enacted. Though ICFI shares an operational framework with Jordan's Principle, the current treatment of Inuit children seeking food supports does not appear to conform to CHRT rulings around Jordan's Principle, which require that Canada meet the needs of (First Nations) children without access to food within 12 hours. ^{6,7}

[Read Chapter 1 - The ICFI-funded Hamlet Food Voucher program: temporary relief from food insecurity](#)

In **Chapter 2**, we draw on key informant interviews and analysis of purchases made with grocery supports to describe the impact of the implementation and discontinuation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. Key informants spoke of pervasive food security challenges that negatively impacted children, caregivers, and communities prior to the Hamlet Food Voucher program. They described a marked improvement in food security once the program was in place. Benefits included reduced hunger and strain on community networks, increased quality of life and purchase of "healthy" foods, as well as improved physical health, school attendance, and social

outcomes. Key informants noted a rapid rise in food insecurity, compounded by the pain of losing access to sufficient food, once the Hamlet Food Voucher program ended.

Read Chapter 2 - The impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program and its discontinuation

In **Chapter 3**, we draw on anonymized records of purchases made by families receiving individual grocery supports and other sources of available data on inflation to examine the impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program on grocery prices in Qikiqtaaluk. We find a growing affordability gap when it comes to grocery prices. The price of a basket of 21 popular food products in Qikiqtaaluk rose from double (2.06 times) that in the rest of Canada in early 2022; to 2.32 times higher by mid-2024. Similar to the rest of Canada, inflation in Qikiqtaaluk was higher in the months *before* the Hamlet Food Voucher programs were implemented (2022 to mid-2023) than afterwards.

Based on the timing of Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption and differences in inflation across communities, it does not appear that the Hamlet Food Voucher program resulted in grocery inflation in Qikiqtaaluk. At most, the impact may have been in the range of 0-2% in a context where average food prices rose by as much as 30% in 2.5 years in some communities. Perceptions of Hamlet Food Voucher related price increases might reflect heightened sensitivity because of the pronounced increase in prices in 2022-23, sharing of extreme prices through social media, shifts in the products that families were able to purchase, or inflation for items not purchased with ICFI grocery supports, which are not captured in our data.

Read Chapter 3 - The Hamlet Food Voucher program and inflation

In **Chapter 4**, we discuss gaps, challenges, and ideas for innovation in the Hamlet Food Voucher program. While key informants valued the Hamlet Food Voucher program and wanted it to continue, they also called for an approach that included more effective means of controlling prices, greater support for the harvesting and distribution of country foods, and a broader range of complementary services and support to address mental health, education, and employment.

When it came to the Hamlet Food Voucher program itself, they called for a less restrictive food security framework that allowed for the purchase of non-food necessities, extended to elders and adults who were not primary caregivers for children, and reflected price variations across communities. At the local level, people worked together to improve the program as much as possible within the Hamlet Food Voucher framework. They experimented with ways to help families stretch their funds across the month, stabilize food supply, and enforce policies restricting purchases to “healthy” food while minimizing tensions related to the exercise of control over community members’ purchases. They also generated ideas about ways to build on the Hamlet Food Voucher Program by incorporating education related to budgeting and nutrition.

Read Chapter 4 - Learning from the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Chapter 1 - The ICFI-funded Hamlet Food Voucher program: Temporary relief from food insecurity

In this chapter, we draw on existing literature to briefly describe food insecurity in the Qikiqtaaluk region of Nunavut as a long-term, systemic problem grounded in colonialism, which has shaped Inuit access to both traditional/country and store-bought food in the region. Long-term, Inuit-developed proposals for solving food insecurity involve a broad set of programs and policies needed to ensure food sovereignty and economic self-reliance. Short-term, interim measures to relieve food insecurity could include a range of government interventions that reduce the price of food and/or supplement benefits like income assistance and child benefits, which do not currently match the cost of living in Nunavut.

We also draw on key informant interviews and Jordan's Principle and ICFI policy documents to describe the trajectory of ICFI-funded supports for food security for Inuit children in Nunavut. During the initial period of ICFI in Nunavut, each family had to individually request grocery supports and submit individualized documentation of need. This approach imposed a heavy administrative burden on families, service providers charged with writing letters of support, and service coordinators who helped facilitate requests. The individualized approach also imposed a heavy administrative burden for ISC. As the number of requests from individual families grew, a backlog developed at ISC; families waited weeks or months for their requests to be assessed.

As a result, hamlets began requesting - and ICFI began funding - "Hamlet Food Voucher programs", which took a universal approach to food security for Inuit children. Because they drastically reduced the administrative burden for families, service providers/coordinators, and ISC, these programs offered an efficient means of extending food security support to Inuit children. Funding for the Hamlet Food Voucher program was discontinued in April of 2025, disrupting Inuit children's food security. In addition, standards and procedures around individual requests shifted dramatically.

Under the terms of new operational standards introduced in February of 2025,⁸ and supervision from the ISC national office, families must navigate significant new barriers when submitting individual requests. Only some requests that link the need for grocery supports directly to a

specific medical issue are being approved; all requests for nutrition supports based on financial need are either directly denied or have delayed decisions because their requests are “escalated” to the national office for review. Canada’s current approach to ICFI does not appear to conform to CHRT rulings around Jordan’s Principle, which require that Canada meet the needs of (First Nations) children without access to food within 12 hours.^{9,10}

To read about any of these topics in more detail, click on a link below.

Food insecurity in Qikiqtaaluk, Nunavut: A systemic problem

Food insecurity in Nunavut

The roots of food insecurity in Nunavut

The current context of food insecurity

The Inuit Child First Initiative as temporary relief for food insecurity in Nunavut

A brief overview of the ICFI

Grocery Supports for individual children (2019-2023)

The shift to Hamlet Food Voucher program (2023-2024)

Growing uncertainty: foundations for the end of the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Food insecurity in Qikiqtaaluk, Nunavut: A systemic problem

Nunavut is one of four Inuit regions in Canada, collectively referred to as Inuit Nunangat. It is the newest territory in Canada, created in 1999. Nunavut has a settled land claims agreement, which created the Government of Nunavut and the Inuit land claims organization, Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated.

This report focuses on the Qikiqtaaluk region, also known as the Qikiqtani or Baffin region.

Qikiqtaaluk is one of three regions in Nunavut. Qikiqtaaluk includes the eastern parts of Nunavut, ranging from the Belcher Islands in the south to all of Baffin Island, and stretching north to the tip of Ellesmere Island. As displayed in Figure 1, the region consists of 13 communities, more than half of the 25 communities in Nunavut, including the capital city of the territory, Iqaluit. Approximately 14,000 Inuit live in the region.¹¹

Figure 1: Map of Qikiqtaaluk (also known as Qikiqtani) communities¹²



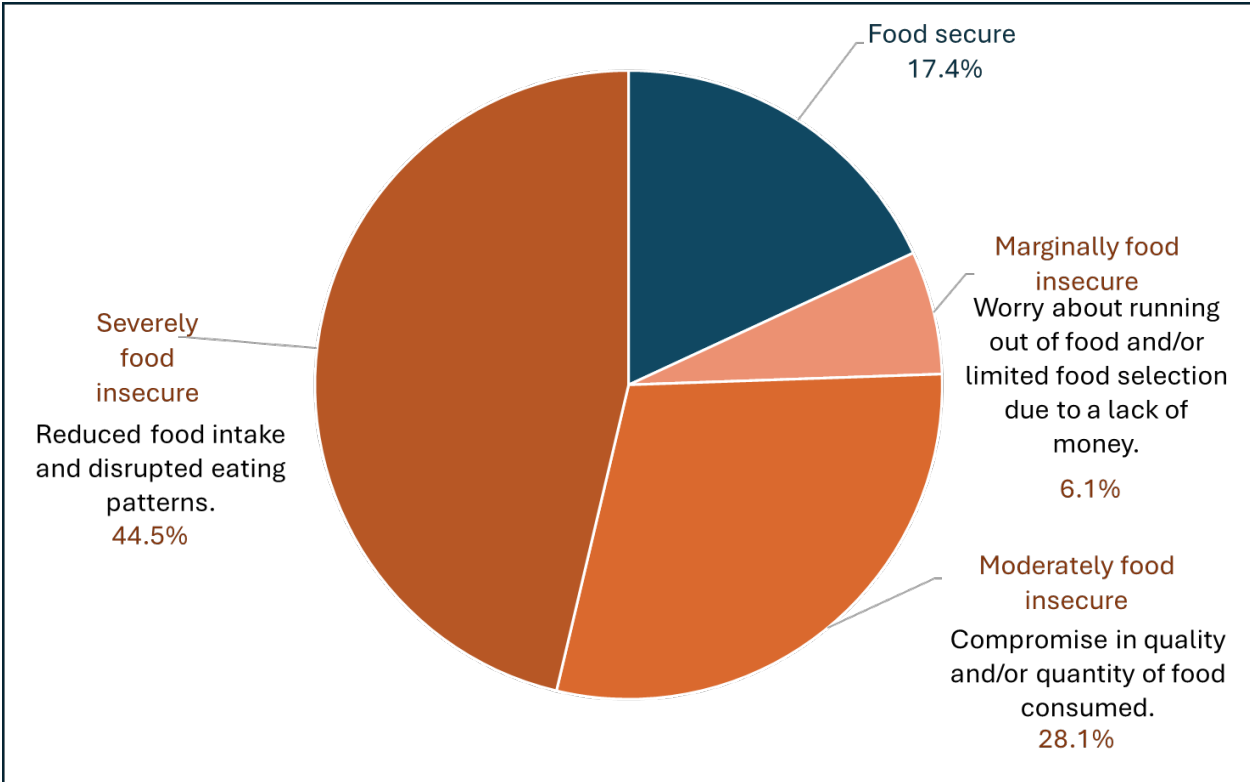
Persistent colonial policies and pressures over the past century have shaped Nunavut Inuit access to food, including both traditional foods (also called ‘country’ foods) and store-bought foods. As the *Inuit Nunangat Food Strategy* highlights, policies such as “relocations, settlement programs, and residential schooling curtailed Inuit mobility and in some cases prevented participation in harvesting activities and the transfer of essential life skills, limiting Inuit self-determination in the development of the Inuit Nunangat food system.”¹³ Other impacts include harvesting regulations and the culling of sled dogs which impacted the ability to remain self-reliant on traditional foods. Many colonial processes, policies, and impacts, including that of the dog killings, have been documented in the Qikiqtani Truth Commission reports.¹⁴

Still, Inuit cultural practices, Inuktitut language use, and knowledge related to hunting, harvesting, and food remain strong in the Qikiqtaaluk region and Nunavut more widely. For example, food sharing practices within communities and families continue today. Further, important work is ongoing to revitalize and support intergenerational knowledge sharing through programs that aim to strengthen self-determination within the Inuit Nunangat food system. Qikiqtani Inuit Association’s (2019) *Food Sovereignty and Harvesting* report¹⁵ and the *Inuit Nunangat Food Security Strategy* (2021)¹⁶ outline important pathways for addressing food insecurity in Inuit communities, including building a harvesting industry, developing harvesting infrastructure, and supporting poverty reduction and economic self-reliance. Increased food security is also one of eight long-term outcomes prioritized in the Nunavut Roundtable for Poverty Reduction’s (2017) *Makimaniq 2* plan.¹⁷

Food insecurity in Nunavut

The Inuit region of Nunavut has the highest rate of food insecurity of any Canadian province/territory.¹⁸ As displayed in Figure 2, 79% of Indigenous children (ages 1-14) in Nunavut lived in households experiencing food insecurity in 2022: 45% of children lived in households in which people experienced reduced food intake or disrupted eating patterns, an additional 28% experienced compromises in quality or quantity of food consumed.¹⁹

Figure 2: Food insecurity for Inuit children (aged 1-14) in Nunavut, 2022²⁰



As summarized in Table 1, the levels of food insecurity, and particularly severe food insecurity, for Inuit children in Nunavut were higher than those for Inuit children in the Northwest Territories, Yukon, and Quebec. In 2017, the percentage of households experiencing food insecurity in Nunavut was 4.5 times the percentage in Canada as a whole.²¹

Table 1: Food Insecurity for Inuit children aged 1-14 (Nunavut, Northwest Territories, Yukon)²²

	Nunavut	Northwest Territories	Yukon	Quebec
Food secure	17.4%	51.60%	64.50%	36.5%
Food insecure	78.70%	46.60%	34.80%	59.4%
Marginally food insecure	6.10%	7%	-	10.6%
Moderately food insecure	28.10%	28.40%	20.80%	31.4%
Severely food insecure	44.50%	11.10%	-	17.4%

The roots of food insecurity in Nunavut

As reflected in the Arctic Region Declaration in Preparation for the 2021 United Nations Global Food Systems Summit, Inuit see food security as being fundamentally linked to issues of sovereignty and self-determination.

Over thousands of years, we have nurtured reciprocal symbiotic and respectful relationships between our peoples and the Arctic environment, and we have transferred our knowledge through countless generations. Our cultural identities, our values, our spirituality, and overall mental and physical wellness are tied to our total environment, of which we are an intimate part of. This is what makes up our food security – our access, availability, stability, health and wellness, cultures, languages, and spirituality. Our governance and stewardship, proven sustainable practices, ownership, decision-making power, and management are all connected to our food sovereignty. Our food sovereignty is tied to the health and wellness of the entire ecosystem and necessary to ensure our food security.²³

These perspectives are reflected in Inuit interpretations and applications of food security concepts originating in the south. For example, in 2014, the Nunavut Food Security Coalition added qualifiers to each of the four most cited aspects of food security to increase the cultural relevance to its people. In their framework, **availability** means enough wildlife on the land or groceries in the store. **Accessibility** is having adequate money for either hunting equipment or groceries, and the ability to obtain them. **Quality** food is culturally valued healthy food, and **use** is the knowledge of how to obtain, store, cook, and consume the available food.²⁴

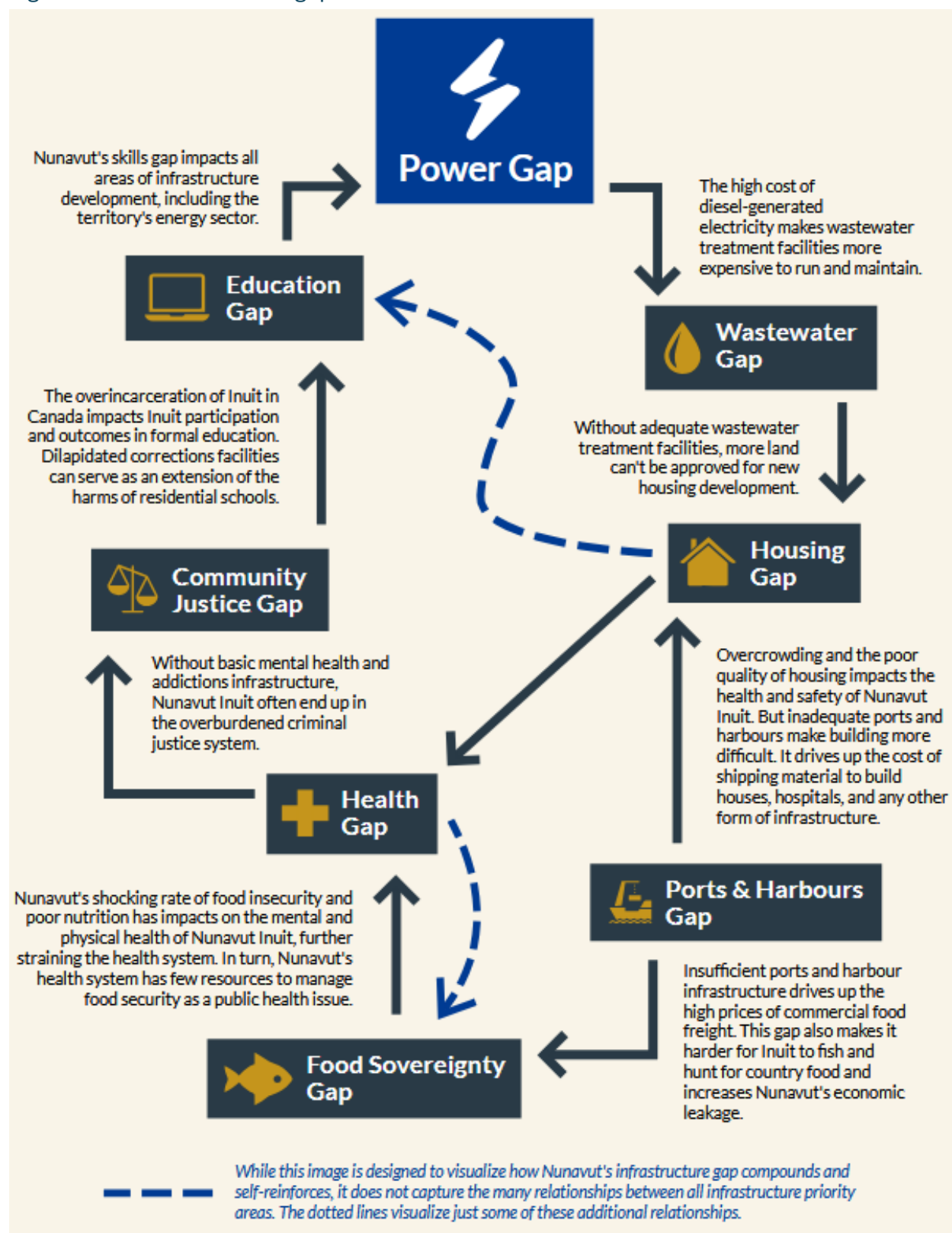
In keeping with this perspective, the persistently high rates of food insecurity in Nunavut can be seen as rooted in the complex impacts of colonialism.²⁵ Healy (2016) gives a concise overview of some of the colonial processes that continue to shape Nunavut, and the high rates of food insecurity in the region today:

The process of relocation to communities, which originally began as a response by Inuit to the presence of traders, explorers, and missionaries, took new form with the systematic efforts of the Canadian government in the 1950s to resettle Canada's North. The Report of

the Royal Commission on Aboriginal Peoples (1996) reports that in these years government administrators were concerned and came to see the North as being in a state of crisis that required immediate attention (INAC, 1996a). The response was to implement resettlement programs in the Eastern Arctic in an effort to: 1) protect Canada's sovereignty after the Second World War; 2) facilitate the opening of trading posts by the Hudson's Bay Company; and 3) police, educate, and provide health care for remote populations (INAC, 1996a; Kirmayer, Brass, & Tait, 2000). As a result, Inuit were relocated to southern Canada to cut relief costs and to provide medical treatment for the tuberculosis epidemics; to remote High Arctic regions to maintain sovereignty and support the economic initiatives of the Hudson's Bay Company; and into settlements to facilitate the provision of supplies, education, and medical care. Increased attention was also directed to reports of Inuit starvation as the number of caribou across the North declined and/or migration patterns changed, particularly in the Kivalliq region of central Nunavut (Tester & Kulchyski, 1994). In approximately the same time period in the 1950s and 1960s, the federal government implemented a policy to remove Inuit children from their families and require them to attend residential school. For some communities, up to three generations of Inuit children were sent away from their families to attend day schools in larger communities (Pauktuutit, 2007).²⁶

Colonial policies and systems of assimilation, such as residential schools and community relocations, have undermined Inuit country food systems and traditional knowledge related to harvesting, processing, and consumption practices.²⁷ In addition, other colonial actions had a lasting impact. For example, prior to colonization, dogs (qimmiit) were used as the primary support for pulling sleds to hunt. During the 1950s as the numbers of both Inuit and Qallunaat (non-Inuit) people living in settlements in Nunavut increased, an ordinance allowing for the killing of "threatening" dogs by the Royal Canadian Mounted Police and other officials began to be used justification for the "elimination of thousands of qimmiit in Qikiqtaaluk. Between 1950 and 1975, the number of qimmiit in Qikiqtaaluk fell from three or four thousand to a few dozen."²⁸ Motorized skidoos were expensive and came with costly equipment maintenance, which increased the cost of country food, putting it out of reach for many.^{29,30,31}

Figure 3: The infrastructure gap in Nunavut³²



Further, land dispossession and colonial introduction of increasing capitalist relations to food (where higher incomes are necessary to afford boats, snowmobiles, gas, and bullets) have led to an increasing reliance on store-bought foods, which are less nutrient-dense than country foods. Additional factors contributing to food insecurity include population growth, harvesting restrictions on wildlife species, climate change (wildlife migratory patterns and the ability to hunt), reduced participation in harvesting across generations, reduction in intergenerational transfer of ecological knowledge, and the disruption of food sharing networks by increasing commercialization of traditional foods.^{33,34}

The current context of food insecurity

High levels of food insecurity have been a long-term and intractable problem in Nunavut. As depicted in Figure 3, food insecurity is shaped by, and compounds, pervasive structural deficits in the region. These infrastructure gaps are a colonial legacy, stemming from inadequate investment and failures to support development of infrastructure adapted for “Inuit social realities or Northern climate realities.”³⁵ For individual families, these gaps pose a web of interlocking challenges, related to food security, that are too complex to examine thoroughly here. As discussed below, these challenges include (but are not limited to): a severe housing shortage – and resulting overcrowding of housing – as well as the high costs of food, and other necessities in a context in which few families have the income required to afford these costs.

High grocery prices persist, in part, because communities in Nunavut are not connected to the south, or even to each other, by road. For most of the year, communities in Nunavut depend on air transportation to supply stores with food brought from food distribution warehouses that are, on average, approximately 2000 km away. In the late summer, communities can receive a limited number of shipments by boat.³⁶ Like many communities in the territorial and provincial north, most communities in Nunavut are served by only one or two grocery stores.³⁷

In this context, government efforts to reduce food insecurity have been ineffective. For example, since the Nutrition North Canada program (NNC), which is described in Textbox

1, was launched in 2011, food insecurity in Northern Canada increased,³⁸ and high food prices persist. NNC subsidized products can be far more expensive than in southern Canada: four litres of milk recently cost \$9.95 in Qikiqtaaluk, compared to the Canadian average of \$5.10.³⁹ Prices for other items can be even higher: a February 2025 video from the hamlet of Grise Fiord shows a jar of jam selling for \$35, pickles for \$66, and a six-pack of apple sauce for \$58.⁴⁰

Textbox 1: Nutrition North Canada – subsidizing groceries in Northern communities^{41,42,43,44}

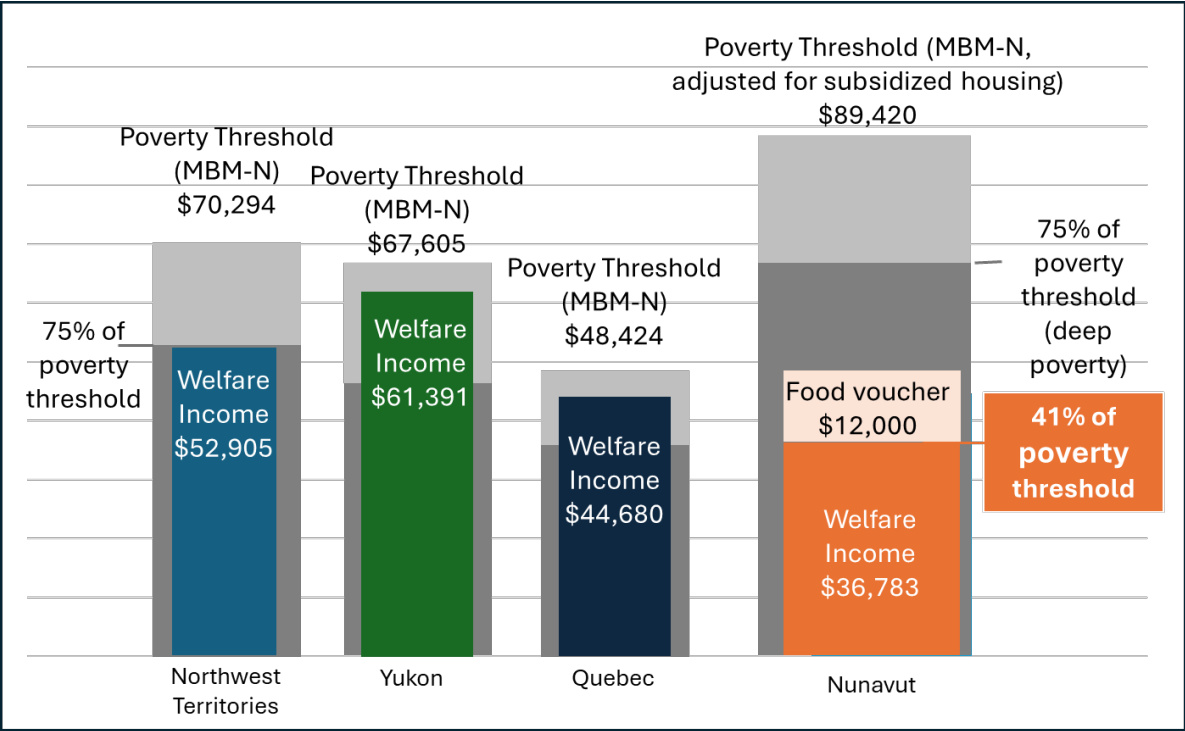
Nutrition North Canada (NNC) is a federal program, implemented in 2011, with the intent of addressing high grocery prices in Northern communities. Replacing the old Food Mail Program, NNC provides direct payments to retailers to subsidize the cost of food in remote northern communities. Existing research suggests that NNC may have increased food insecurity by implementing subsidy payments for expensive, perishable foods that have not kept pace with rising costs.

The NNC program model does not include price controls. Instead, it relies on market competition to encourage retailers and suppliers to lower prices for subsidized foods. In a setting with limited competition and accountability, retailers are paid a subsidy per kilogram of food shipped, with rates that vary by community and product (e.g. those deemed more nutritious receive higher subsidy levels). They are expected to pass-through the savings to customers. Households in a community benefit in proportion to their spending on subsidized products and do not need to apply for the subsidy. Unfortunately, the current iteration of the retail subsidy still covers a small set of eligible goods that is not relevant for all northern Indigenous communities.

In addition to policies and programs focused explicitly on food security, the context of food security is directly shaped by other policies and programs that address poverty and the cost of living. Because individuals have more direct control over food costs than the cost of housing, utilities, and other essentials, they may reduce food costs and/or consumption to make ends meet. From this perspective, the high rate of food insecurity in Nunavut reflects a vast gap between household incomes and the resources required for a basic standard of living.

The employment rate in Nunavut is lower than in other regions: in early 2025, the unemployment rate in Nunavut was 13%, much higher than that in Northwest Territories, Yukon, or any region of Quebec.⁴⁵ Accordingly, in 2022, approximately 41.8% of children (aged 0-17) in Nunavut lived in households classified as poor based on the low-income measure (household income that is 50% below the income of the median household). The median income for poor households with two adults and two children was just under \$36,000.

Figure 4: Northern Market Basket Measure (MBM-N) poverty thresholds and welfare income for a family with 2 adults and 2 children (Northwest Territories, Yukon, Quebec, and Nunavut)⁴⁶



The social assistance, or welfare income (including federal and provincial/territorial social assistance, child tax benefits, and tax credits; see Appendix 3), available to a low-income family of two adults and two children in Nunavut in 2023 was \$36,783.^{47,48} Federal benefits were equal across provinces/territories and did not reflect the cost of living. Social assistance provided by Nunavut lagged behind other provinces/territories with northern regions; income support in Nunavut was less than half that in the Northwest Territories and

the Yukon and the Nunavut child benefit was a fraction of that provided by Yukon, Northwest Territories, and Quebec.

Figure 4 shows Northern Market Basket Measure (MBM-N) poverty thresholds and welfare incomes for the Northwest Territories, the Yukon, Nunavut, and Quebec. The welfare income available to low-income Nunavut families is comparable to that in lower-cost-of-living provinces/territories, and Nunavut is the jurisdiction with the largest gap between welfare income and the poverty threshold. Welfare income (and the median income for low-income households) for a family with two adults and two children was around 40% of the \$89,420 needed for a 2-adult, 3-child family, living in social housing in Iqaluit, to afford the “modest, basic standard of living” represented by the official poverty threshold (also known as the MBM-N poverty threshold).⁴⁹ Welfare income is only 41% of the MBM-N poverty threshold, for families living in subsidized housing, in Nunavut. Thus, even with \$1,000 a month in food vouchers, a family of four making the median income for families in poverty remains far below the “deep poverty” threshold of 75% of the official poverty line.⁵⁰

The challenge of making ends meet is even more pronounced for the many families that cannot secure social housing. In 2023, 2,900 households were on the waitlist for public housing. Every community in Nunavut had a waitlist for public housing, and 45% of homes were overcrowded.⁵¹ In order for a two-bedroom apartment in the region to be affordable, an annual income of over \$115,000 was required.⁵² Accordingly, food security is an ongoing challenge.

The Inuit Child First Initiative as temporary relief for food insecurity in Nunavut

A brief overview of the ICFI

Recently, key efforts to address food insecurity have been funded through the Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI), which is intended to “help families access necessary services without delay.”⁵³ The ICFI was developed when Natan Obed, President of Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami, the national organization representing Inuit in Canada, wrote to Prime Minister Justin Trudeau in March of 2018. He expressed “deep concern regarding Canada’s denial of services to Inuit Children and Youth under Jordan’s Principle,” “a human rights principle established by

the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) to make sure that First Nations children do not face gaps, delays, or denials in accessing government services because of their identity as First Nations children.”^{54,55}

ICFI was announced in September 2018 as a temporary measure put in place “while an Inuit-specific framework is being developed.”⁵⁶ The stated goal of ICFI is to ensure that Inuit children (under age 19) “have equal access to essential government funded health, social and educational products, services and supports.”⁵⁷ Since its initiation, ICFI has been funded through temporary budget allocations. An initial allocation of \$220 million over five years was announced in 2019. An additional \$167.5 million was allocated to extend ICFI for two years, from April 1, 2023, to March 31, 2025. On March 21, 2025, Minister Hajdu (ISC) announced \$121.7 million to extend the Inuit Child First Initiative until March 31, 2026.⁵⁸

Through Jordan’s Principle and ICFI, the federal government responds to:

- **Individual requests** for services/supports/equipment to meet individual First Nation and Inuit children’s needs.
- **Group requests** for funding for programs or services that meet the needs of groups of First Nations and Inuit children.^{59,60}

The standards and procedures for submission, assessment, and response to these requests have evolved and shifted over time. These changes have been partially shaped by a series of rulings, issued by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal (CHRT) since 2016, in *First Nations Child and Family Caring Society & Assembly of First Nations et al v. Canada* (*Caring Society v. Canada*) and have also been driven by other policy and administrative considerations.

In keeping with CHRT rulings, both ICFI and Jordan’s Principle requests are assessed with respect to a standard of substantive equality,^{61,62} a legal principle focused on achieving equality of *outcomes*.⁶³ “Achieving substantive equality for members of a specific group requires the implementation of measures that consider and are tailored to respond to the

unique causes of their historical disadvantage as well as their historical, geographical and cultural needs and circumstances.”⁶⁴

The CHRT rulings around Jordan’s Principle have focused on First Nations children; groups representing Inuit children have not been party to *Caring Society v. Canada*. However, ICFI has “operationally ... mirrored Jordan’s Principle processes since its creation in 2018.”⁶⁵ As invoked in *Caring Society v. Canada*, the *Canadian Human Rights Act (CHRA)* states that:

It is a discriminatory practice in the provision of goods, services, facilities or accommodation customarily available to the general public:

(a) to deny, or to deny access to, any such good, service, facility or accommodation to any individual, or

(b) to differentiate adversely in relation to any individual,

on a prohibited ground of discrimination.⁶⁶

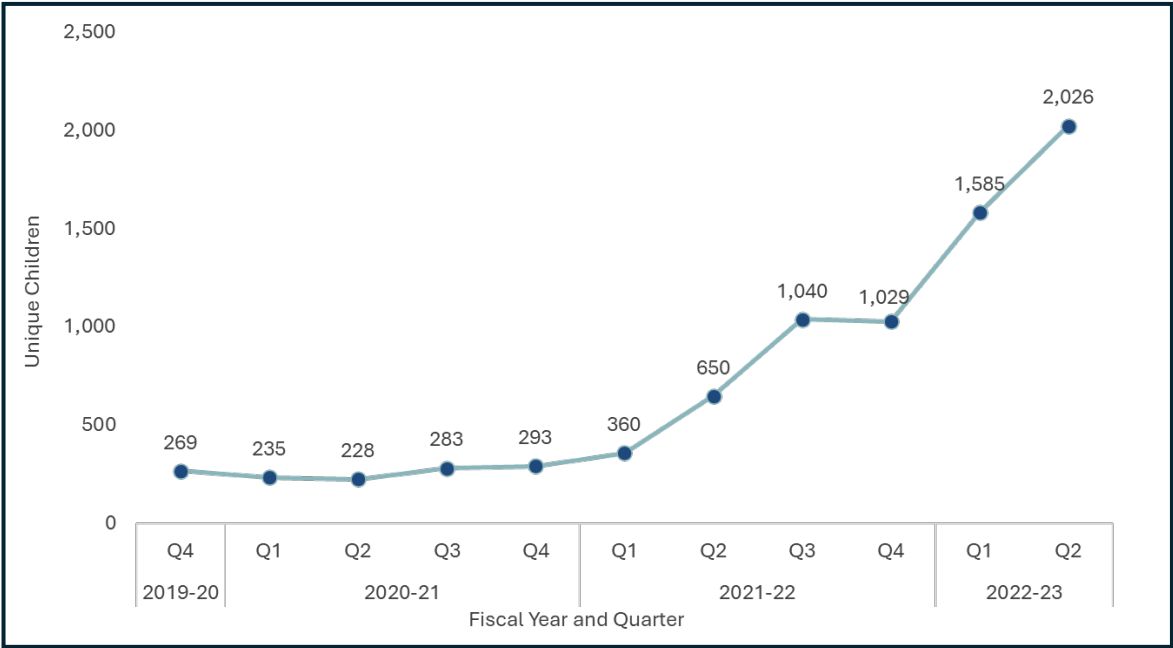
These grounds include “ethnic origin.”⁶⁷

Grocery Supports for individual children (2019-2023)

As in most regions that implemented Jordan’s Principle,⁶⁸ requests for ICFI funding were limited at first, then grew sharply. As shown in Figure 5, there were fewer than 500 children with approved requests per quarter across all of Inuit Nunangat in 2019-20 and 2020-21. Use of ICFI increased starting in 2021-22, growing over 600%, with over 2,000 additional children receiving approved requests by the final quarter of 2022-23.^a

In Nunavut, the request process was aided by Qupanuaq, an Arctic Children and Youth Foundation service coordination program that supports families, and by a southern service coordination organization, Indigenous Kids Network. By 2021-22, 39% of requests were in the category of healthy child development, which includes support for food security as well as purchase of car seats, rent, utilities, clothing, household supplies, and other basic needs.⁶⁹

Figure 5: Total approved requests by land claim region, fiscal years 2019-20 to 2021-22^a



Service coordinators and ISC staff members working in the regional office noted that grocery supports quickly became the most common request in Nunavut. Reflecting on the scope of requests related to food security in Nunavut, an ISC staff member noted:

ICFI was never meant to be an income supplement, but it's clear what the issue is, people cannot afford food. The original intention was to support children's medical needs, gaps, and services such as assessments which are difficult to access. And those supports are still important. But when basic needs like food and housing aren't being met, supports such as psychoeducational assessments become secondary, they go hand in hand.

Similarly, a service coordinator spoke about food insecurity from a family services perspective.

There's overcrowding in homes. While parents may be getting money for child tax or things like that, to support their children with the very basics, they may be living in a home of not just their children, and there's not enough food on the table. ... it leaves children hungry. That's the basis of it ... children are hungry.

Initially, the ICFI-funded response to food insecurity in Nunavut came in the form of grocery supports provided to families who made individual requests. These supports were initially set to cover an amount based on the northern food basket measure in the hamlet where a child lived. ISC subsequently decided to provide a fixed amount across communities: \$500 per child per month, and an extra \$250 per month was provided for diapers and other supplies for children under the age of four. The timeline of funding provided through grocery supports shifted over time, moving between six months and one year. Grocery supports could potentially be renewed with submission of a new individual request.

There was no formal, regional or community-wide communication to families informing them that they might be eligible for grocery supports. Instead, news of the program was spread by word of mouth. The documentation required with a request included a letter of support from a service provider (typically a social worker or medical provider, though ISC lists health and educational professionals as well as elders/knowledge keepers as possible letter sources⁷⁰) that spoke to a child's specific situation and provided justification for provision of grocery supports. From the outset, this process was unwieldy, as it depended on service providers to provide letters of support that satisfied ISC's assessment standards. A service coordinator described a situation in which she provided a support letter this way:

I've had parents calling and crying over the phone because they're unable to feed their children. ...In this situation, I actually wrote the letter of support for this family, and it took at least two hours to prepare and make sure the letter of support has all the information, all the child's information and the families' financial ... situation, and also I requested this work to be urgent and that the family would not have enough food to last ... two and a half weeks until Child Tax.

She noted that, in that case, the request was approved directly, but she contrasted that case with another in which the service provider's letter was not as detailed as the one that she prepared.

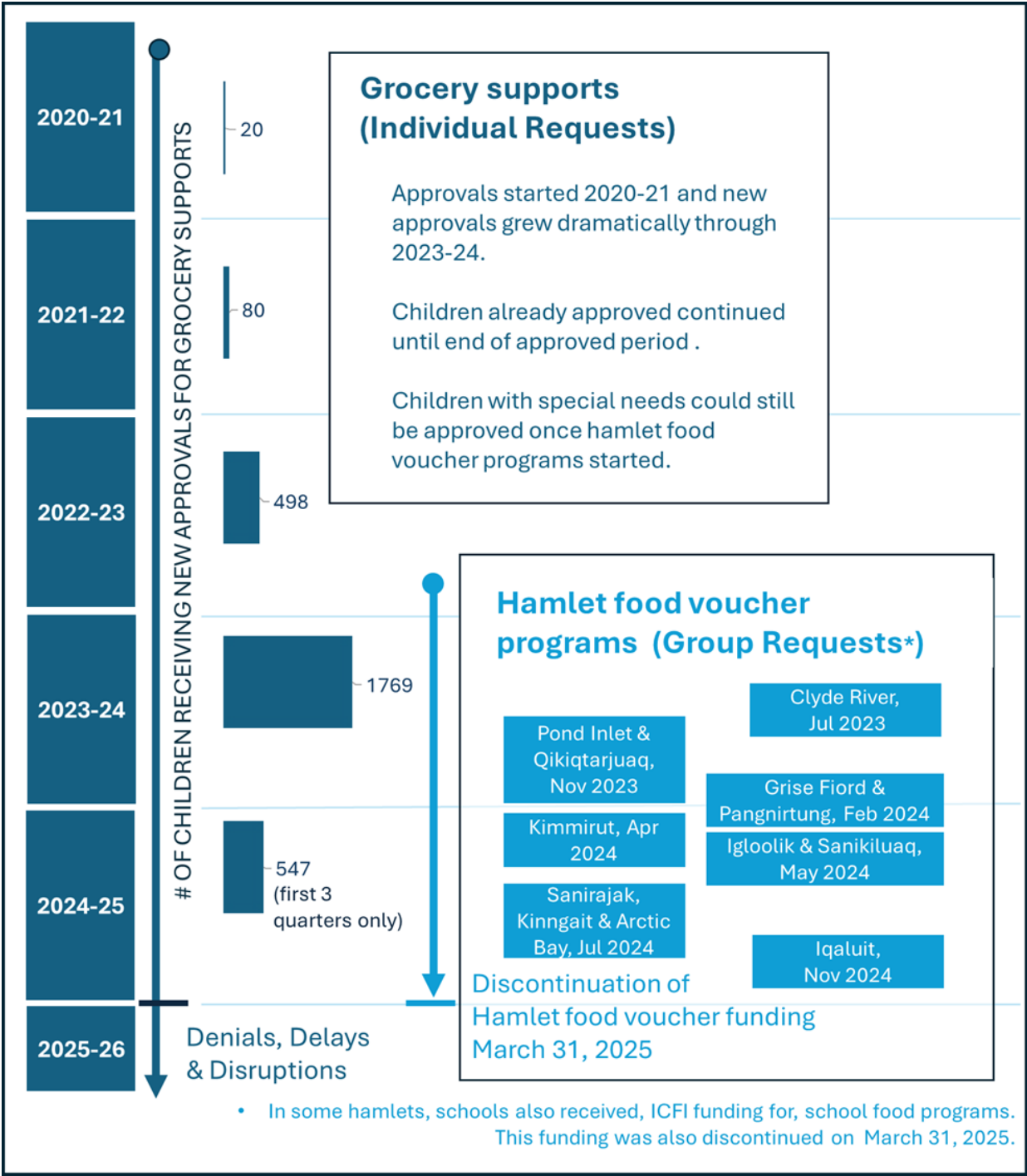
I send it [a request for grocery supports] as soon as possible when parents say that they don't have any food right now, but ... [the needed information is] not in the letter of support, because they dropped it off to our office. So, then we had to ask for a revised letter of support and then resend it. So that caused a delay of between three to seven days.

Others noted that, in a context with frequent turnover in some service provider positions like nurses, doctors, and social workers, it could be difficult for families to obtain service provider letters that spoke to their unique circumstances. Thus, the process placed a heavy burden on both service providers and families. It depended on a family hearing about the existence of grocery supports from someone in their network, pursuing a request, and accessing a service provider who was able/willing to provide a letter.

Accordingly, data shared by ISC indicated that the proportion of families receiving grocery supports varied greatly across hamlets. By the end of the 2023-24 fiscal year, roughly 30% of the child population in Qikiqtaaluk had received a grocery supports approval. Across hamlets, the percentage of children receiving grocery supports ranged from very close to 0% to just over 60%; and fewer than 20% of children had been approved for grocery supports in 6 of the 13 communities in Qikiqtaaluk.⁷¹ Despite the variation across hamlets, the overall number of individual requests for grocery supports grew dramatically in Qikiqtaaluk in 2022-23 and 2023-24. As shown in Figure 6 (based on data for children with approved grocery supports requests in Qikiqtaaluk, shared by ISC), almost 1800 children received new approvals for grocery supports in 2023-24.

As the number of requests increased, a backlog of cases that needed to be assessed emerged at ISC. An ISC staff member working in the regional office shared that the backlog sometimes included over 1,000 cases, and both ISC staff and service providers/coordinators shared that the delay in response to an individual request could be as long as several months, or even over a year. During these delays, families went without the grocery supports they had requested to ensure they could meet the needs of their children.

Figure 6: Timeline of ICFI-funded food security supports in Qikiqtaaluk ^{72,73}



Shift to Hamlet Food Voucher program (2023-2024)

To more efficiently meet the needs of Inuit children, Nunavut hamlets began to request - and receive - ICFI funding for nutrition supports for all Inuit children in the community. Indigenous Kids Network (IKN) supported the development of the first Hamlet Food Voucher program application, and the first program began in July 2023. As represented in Figure 6, other hamlets, supported primarily by IKN and (in some cases) by Qupanuaq, followed suit when they had the capacity to take on administration of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. (For a description of the requirements and burden involved in administering the program, see Appendix 4.) By December 2024, all but one community in Nunavut had received funding for a Hamlet Food Voucher program.⁷⁴

In keeping with the funding levels that ISC established for individual grocery supports, these programs provided \$500 per child for groceries and an additional \$250 for diapers for children under four years old. In contrast with individual requests, the Hamlet Food Voucher programs appeared to have quickly enrolled almost all eligible children in a hamlet. According to Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators/SAO officials and service providers/coordinators we spoke with, there were initial delays and challenges in some communities, but enrollment of eligible children was near universal after the initial period. Registration was a relatively straightforward process that required parents to provide verification of a child's age and Inuit identity. Accordingly, the Hamlet Food Voucher program was able to meet family needs much more efficiently than individual grocery supports. An ISC staff member described the difference this way:

On the individual side, we've had a lot of cases where it's like, we have a request that's maybe been on a backlog for a bit, or we get a new request for groceries and we say, 'Have you heard about this [the Hamlet Food Voucher program]? Go to them.' And it's like, right away, they're able to do that.

As detailed in Chapter 2 of this report, key informants we spoke with noted positive impacts of the Hamlet Food Voucher programs, including reductions in hunger, increased purchase of "healthy" foods, improvements in physical health, and social benefits at the

individual, family, and community levels. Though they had concerns about limitations in the program framework and ideas about improvement moving forward (see Chapter 4 of this report), almost all key informants said the Hamlet Food Voucher program was a positive development and looked forward to the program's continuation.

Growing uncertainty: foundations for the end of the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Still, by the time we started conducting key informant interviews, in the last months of 2024, uncertainty about the future of the Hamlet Food Voucher program was already starting to emerge. In the national context, there was growing concern over the backlog of unprocessed Jordan's Principle requests, the scale and scope of approved requests, and possible misuse of Jordan's Principle funds.⁷⁵ At the local level, leaders in Nunavut raised concerns about rising retail grocery prices and questioned whether inflation could be tied to the implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program; they called for an "audit" of retail prices.⁷⁶

A November 2024 letter decision from the CHRT, expanded on in a January 2025 ruling, laid the foundation for a major shift in the federal approach to Jordan's Principle and the ICFI. It reinforced some key aspects of Jordan's Principle, including a presumption of substantive equality, the need to keep supporting documentation minimal, and guidelines for professional identification of urgent cases. The decision also tightened the standards for declaration of urgent cases, mandated ISC to immediately deal with its backlogged cases, and allowed Canada greater flexibility in the prioritization, treatment, and classification of Jordan's Principle requests.^{77,78}

In this context, ISC staff working with the ICFI in Nunavut expressed concerns about the future of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. They supported the continuation of the program until a viable alternative, that better addressed the root causes of food insecurity in the region, could be implemented. However, they also noted that, because of its cost, the program might be "unsustainable." They suggested that, if the Hamlet Food Voucher program was ended, the default would be to return to a system based on individual requests. One ISC staff member expressed concerns about that possibility:

The sheer cost of, like processing a request ... the number of staff that we need to review all those individual requests, versus ... you know, put in a multi-year agreement in place with a hamlet on the group side, that also needs to be taken into account.

They noted that any cost savings were likely to reflect the front-end burden that the individual request system placed on children and families.

If we stop these [Hamlet Food Voucher programs], it's going to go back to the individual side, and that cost is going to be almost the same. It will be lower, but it will be lower because we don't have the staff to keep up with the number of requests coming in, or there's ... some families that won't be in a position or have the capacity to submit individual requests for, you know, a number of reasons.

Questions about the future of ICFI-funded grocery supports were compounded in February of 2025, when ISC released an "operational bulletin" outlining a new approach to ICFI.⁷⁹ The bulletin noted that existing or previously approved requests would be reviewed on a case-by-case basis, and introduced stricter standards for both individual and group request submission.^c

The narrowed standards for approval of Jordan's Principle funding identified a wide range of supports that would "not be approved unless such funding is required by substantive equality" and would be denied "unless accompanied medical professional's letter of support indicating child-specific recommendation based on the child's specific needs." The listed supports included those to ensure basic needs such as childcare, clothing, furniture, and vehicles.⁸⁰ Conspicuously missing from this list was support for access to food, which was explicitly identified in the November 2024 and January 2025 CHRT decisions as a basis for classification as an urgent case:

^cThe new standards for group request submissions that seem very similar to those implemented in Alberta, which had the lowest rate of group request approvals in Canada, prior to adoption of the Back to Basics approach. See pgs 54-55 of [this report](#) for summary of a case study of group request approval under these standards.

The Tribunal agrees that a child with no access to food or other basic necessities is considered an urgent case requiring action within 12 hours.^{81,82}

Concerns about the future of ICFI were compounded in January when, amidst ongoing conflict within the Liberal party, Prime Minister Justin Trudeau announced his resignation and prorogued parliament until March 24, 2025. With ICFI funding set to expire on March 31, 2025, it was unclear whether ICFI would be continued and, if so, how long Hamlet Food Voucher funding and other supports would be disrupted before additional ICFI funding would be approved. Hopes were temporarily raised on March 21, when Minister Hajdu (ISC) announced \$121.7 million to extend the Inuit Child First Initiative until March 31, 2026.⁸³

Denials, delays, and disruptions

Hopes for the continuation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program were short-lived. Neither program coordinators nor hamlet leadership received information about when ICFI funds would flow or how the extension of funding or shift in standards would impact the program. Some Hamlet Food Voucher programs closed and laid off staff early in April; others were able to temporarily continue the program using previously allocated, unspent funds.

Hamlets that moved forward with reapplication in a state of uncertainty scrambled to meet new guidelines.⁸⁴ These guidelines required “child’s name, date of birth, and confirmation of their eligibility for the Inuit Child First Initiative” for each child as well as “a letter of support that demonstrates how the requested product, service, or support links directly to the children’s unmet health, social, or educational needs.”⁸⁵

Re-applications for group funding for the Hamlet Food Voucher program were denied. An email from an ISC staff member working in the regional office to NTI noted that:

[Indigenous Services Canada] has determined, based on its analysis of legal obligations related to substantive equality under the Inuit Child First Initiative, that funding for universal food voucher programs will not be approved.⁸⁶

Still, in May, a service coordinator shared that not all hamlets understood that ISC had ended the Hamlet Food Voucher programs. She said:

Hamlets have reached out to me personally and said, you know, we're still waiting, we're still in a review process. And they're telling us ... 'Emails ISC are sending us are hopeful, or making us hopeful, that this program is going to be supported,' but we know that that's not the case ... ISC has informed us Hamlet Food Voucher programs are not going to be supported.

In June of 2025, at least one hamlet continued to operate a Hamlet Food Voucher program using unspent funds from their 2024-25 budget; at least nine Nunavut hamlets publicly confirmed the end of the voucher program by the end of April,⁸⁷ and most seemed to have ended the programs.

In this context, families were left uncertain about the future of the Hamlet Food Voucher programs and unprepared for the cut-off of food voucher funding. Service coordinators/providers shared that, even in May of 2025, some families wondered whether the program would soon be restarted.

A lot of families have mentioned that they would love to receive the vouchers coming back, but we don't know. I don't think they're coming back ... I don't know.

In the absence of ICFI group funding for the Hamlet Food Voucher program, service providers/coordinators supported families in making individual requests for grocery supports; but this form of ICFI funding also appeared to have been nearly eliminated. Service coordinators spoke of widespread denials of requests for grocery supports. They also reported that almost all requests were being "escalated" to national for review; delays and increased denials in response to escalated requests have been previously documented.^{88,89} Some denials were delivered without explanation; some families received messages saying an explanation for denial was forthcoming, but they did not receive further communication.

The CHRT mandated response timelines for Jordan's Principle cases: response to individual Jordan's Principle requests must occur within 48 hours of receiving all documentation and within 12 hours for urgent requests. Urgent group requests must be assessed within 48 hours and other requests within one week.

CHRT rulings on Jordan's Principle issued in November of 2024 and January of 2025 tightened the standards for declaration of urgent cases, and allowed Canada greater flexibility in the prioritization, treatment, and classification of Jordan's Principle requests. At the same time, the CHRT reaffirmed that "a child with no access to food or other basic necessities is considered an urgent case requiring action within 12 hours."

As shown in the screenshot below, the federal government webpage for Jordan's Principle (for First Nations children) begins with clear instructions around urgent requests. In contrast, in June 2025, the government web page for ICFI made **no** mention of urgent cases.



Urgent requests

If you have an urgent request that meets the following interim criteria, please contact the Jordan's Principle Call Centre at [1-855-JP-CHILD](tel:1-855-JP-CHILD) ([1-855-572-4453](tel:1-855-572-4453)). This could include:

- life threatening cases
- cases involving end-of-life or palliative care
- risk of suicide
- risk to physical safety
- no access to food or basic necessities
- risk of entering the child welfare system
- caregivers and children fleeing from domestic violence

This interim criteria of urgent was clarified by the Canadian Human Rights Tribunal ruling 2025 CHRT 6.

Urgent requests for products, services or supports under Jordan's Principle must be directly linked to the child's urgent circumstances.

Requests are reviewed on a case-by-case basis. There may be some time-sensitive requests that are urgent, but are not covered by the above.

Requests were escalated even when submissions met all criteria outlined in the February operational bulletin and included service provider letters explaining why a child required access to food as well as photos of empty pantries and refrigerators. One service coordinator shared:

So far, every application that I've sent for individual food supports have been escalated to national level, even when we're providing a picture of absolutely no food in a family's home.

She qualified this response, noting:

We did have one with a child who has, like, a severe food restriction, where it's difficult to find safe foods for this child, and so the supports for that child were accepted.

However, service coordinators suggested that this was an exception, even for children with nutrition-related medical needs. They shared stories of denials or partial denials of requests for grocery supports for children requiring specialized nutrition and diets. For example, one service coordinator shared a case in which a child with diabetes was approved for a limited time frame (3 months rather than 6 months) because they previously received Hamlet Food Voucher support. Another shared the case of a child whose body processes sugar differently and, as a result, requires a special diet. She said:

We had thought that it would be an immediate approval from ISC, because the letter of support came from a pediatrician, saying ... 'the child is losing weight, the child is in need of certain grocery items that the family cannot afford, and the child has now started a new medication that's impacting [their] appetite, which the family has stopped because they can't let the child lose any more weight,' and that is sitting in escalation for the last three weeks.

All requests for nutrition supports based on financial need are either directly denied or have delayed decisions because their requests are "escalated" to the national office for review. A statement from ISC provides federal justification for this approach:

It [ICFI] is not intended nor structured to displace government income assistance through universal programs such as food vouchers.”⁹³

In at least some communities, the end of the Hamlet Food Voucher program and restrictions on individual grocery support occurred concurrently with the end of school food programs that were also funded through ICFI. While Canada and Nunavut reached a bilateral agreement on funding for school food programs in February of 2025, service coordinators reported that funding sufficient to continue the school food programs did not seem to be available at the local level.⁹⁴

The denial of nutrition supports to Inuit children in Nunavut does not seem to be in accordance with recent CHRT rulings on Jordan’s Principle. November 2024 and January 2025 CHRT rulings on Jordan’s Principle clarified response to request for basic necessities: **“once food or other basic necessities have been provided** [emphasis added] it is appropriate to refer the family to other non-discriminatory services, and if the services include barriers, to eliminate those barriers [emphasis added].” However, in the cases shared by service coordinators/providers in Nunavut, children’s immediate needs for food were not addressed. Given the delays in response to applications for grocery supports and a broad gap between the level of income supports and the official poverty line in Nunavut (see Figure 4, above), many families were unable to purchase needed groceries and did not have access to alternate services/supports. We discuss the impact of the disruption and termination of Hamlet Food Voucher programs, and of the new, restrictive approach to grocery supports in Chapter 2 of this report.

Textbox 3: Administrative barriers to accessing grocery supports through

Jordan's Principle emerged in response to persistent administrative barriers to services for First Nations children. Still, in the years following their public commitments to implementing Jordan's Principle, federal and provincial/territorial governments enacted so many barriers to accessing services through Jordan's Principle that they were able to claim that there were "no Jordan's Principle cases in Canada." Rulings on Jordan's Principle made by the CHRT since 2016 responded to ongoing administrative barriers to service access. In the context of national discourse around preventing "misuse" of Jordan's Principle funding, administrative barriers to accessing ICFI funded food security supports increased for Qikiqtaaluk families in 2025. These barriers can be seen as a series of questions that families must correctly answer to access support:

1. **Is your child Inuk?** An answer of 'yes' is essential to accessing ICFI supports *and* it places a family on a pathway that does not conform to CHRT mandates that a request from a [First Nations] child who lacks access to food or other basic necessities is *urgent* and must be addressed within 12 hours. Inuit families encounter systematic delays as their requests are escalated to the national ISC office for review. To have their requests considered, Inuit families must also provide "correct" answers to other key questions.
2. **Does your child have access to the food they need?** An answer of "no" is an insufficient basis for a request.
3. **Can you produce documentation, from a *licensed professional* that clearly links the need for grocery supports to your child's specific needs?** In a Nunavut context in which staff shortages have recently disrupted both health and social services, accessing a licensed professional that is familiar with a child's specific needs poses a serious barrier to meeting this requirement.
4. **Can the service provider attest to *the distinct needs your child has for food based on their scope of practice*?** It is not clear what individualized assessments or diagnoses would be appropriate to justify a child's distinct need for food.
5. **Can the service provider demonstrate that your child *experienced gaps or delays in accessing government services, or was denied an existing government service because of their identity as an Inuk child*?** As demonstrated by the persistently high levels of food insecurity in Nunavut, and reinforced in Chapter 2 of this report, existing government services do not adequately address food security. Demonstrating this systemic gap in services is a heavy burden for service providers or families to meet.
6. **Has your child received grocery supports, or support through the Hamlet Food Voucher program in the last 6 months?** Children who needed support to access food in the last 6 months may only qualify for reduced supports.

Chapter 2 - The impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program and its discontinuation

In this chapter, we draw on key informant interviews and analysis of purchases made with grocery supports to describe the impact of the implementation and discontinuation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. In keeping with existing data, which shows that most Inuit children in Nunavut experience food insecurity,¹⁰² key informants spoke of pervasive challenges in affording food prior to the Hamlet Food Voucher program. These challenges were a part of everyday life and negatively impacted children, caregivers, and extended families, straining both formal and informal community food security resources.

Key informants noted marked improvement in food security and discussed positive impacts once the Hamlet Food Voucher program was in place. These included, but were not limited to, reduced hunger, increased purchase of “healthy” foods, and improved physical health, school attendance, and social outcomes, as well as increased quality of life, and reduced strain on community networks.

Once the Hamlet Food Voucher program ended, key informants noted a rapid return to the situation as it was before the Hamlet Food Voucher program. However, the challenges were compounded by the damage of having access to food that people had come to experience as necessary and normal being taken away.

To read about any of these topics in more detail, click on a link below.

Before the Hamlet Food Voucher program

During the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Reduced hunger

Purchase of healthy foods

Impacts of increased access to food

Beyond physical health

After the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Before the Hamlet Food Voucher program

When asked to describe the situation in Qikiqtaaluk communities before the implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, key informants shared stories of widespread struggles to access food and discussed a range of strategies that families used to manage when they could not regularly access the food they needed. A key informant who worked with a Hamlet Food Voucher program/SAO office drew on her own experience to describe the ways in which parents and other adults ensured that their children had food.

I've seen a lot [of] families struggle. I myself had it before too, and I have children of my own, I [would] go like few days without meals, just so I can feed my kids.

A service provider/coordinator suggested that the high cost of food affected the types of foods that families purchased, noting that the foods they were able to purchase were of “lower nutritional value” and did not include “fresh fruits and vegetables.”

A Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO office employee shared strategies that families used to access food when they didn't have the funds to purchase groceries. He said:

They usually try to sell their personal stuff ... They would try to get hunting, and that's pretty much it.

Other key informants spoke of strategies in which families reached out to people in their networks to ask for help in accessing food. One spoke of her prior experience of working in a child and family services office, sharing that:

I've seen repeatedly people coming into the office just asking, you know, 'do you have flour so I can make bannock, like, can you give me anything at all? Because I can't afford to go to the grocery store this month.'

A key informant working in an SAO's office described the ways that people reached out to other community members for food support:

You would have seen a lot of, like, ‘Can I borrow 40 bucks ‘til Friday? I have no food’ ... ‘Can anybody, please, does anybody have any like noodles or rice, just anything, because I had nothing to give my kids?’

Some key informants noted that the sharing of food and funds with families who were struggling to access food strained the resources of family and community networks. One key informant summarized this succinctly, saying: “We see a lot of families helping each other, whether they can [afford it] or not. “

A service coordinator expanded on this, describing the strain on informal social networks and organizations seeking to improve food security in the community.

Most often it’s ... one family who makes enough money to be able to feed people ... for example, there’s a family struggling, and they’ll often go to, like, different family homes or go to the soup kitchen. But, they might not always make it to the soup kitchen because they always run out of food. The Food Bank also often runs out of food ... And this really affects, you know, mental health or well-being and everything.

During the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Key informants noted marked improvement in food security and discussed positive impacts once the Hamlet Food Voucher program was in place. These included, but were not limited to, reduced hunger, increased purchase of “healthy” foods, and improved physical health, school attendance, and social outcomes, as well as increased quality of life, and reduced strain on community networks.

A key complicating factor in assessing the impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program is that ICFI funded other forms of food security support during the same period in which the program operated: some families continued to receive grocery supports and some children/youth also benefited from ICFI-funded school food programs. We are not currently able to distinguish between the effects of different programs. In this section of the report, we rely primarily on key informant statements about the Hamlet Food Voucher program, but we draw on discussions of grocery supports when needed to illustrate impacts for

individual children and data on grocery support purchases in discussion of access to healthy foods.

Reduced hunger

All key informants indicated that the Hamlet Food Voucher was improving food security. When asked about the impacts of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, one key informant answered in very clear and simple terms: “They’ll eat three times a day; that’s pretty helpful.”

Many key informants suggested the program had a direct and desired impact: reducing child hunger. For instance, one key informant, who worked with the Hamlet Food Voucher program, said:

Children are less hungry. The parents are asking less on Facebook to get donations with food. And there’s always people that thank me for working here because it’s helping them at home.

Others noted that the program also benefited adults who were previously sacrificing their own nutrition to make sure that children were fed.

I think it helped a lot of families to not go hungry ... even for mothers and parents, because some people would go [without food] for at least couple days as long as their children are eating.

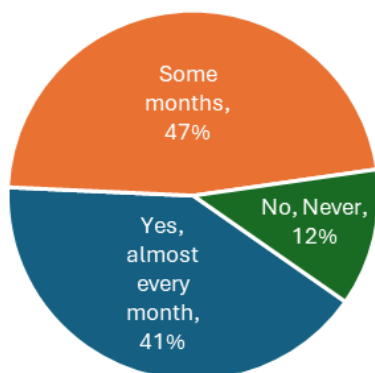
Beyond the benefits for individual families, key informants noted that the Hamlet Food Voucher program reduced strain on family/community networks. Key informants noted that they were seeing fewer Facebook messages from community members asking for extra food or to borrow money for food. One described messages from people asking for food in Facebook groups being posted at a “fraction” of what they used to be.

Textbox 4: Results from an evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program in Pangnirtung¹⁰³

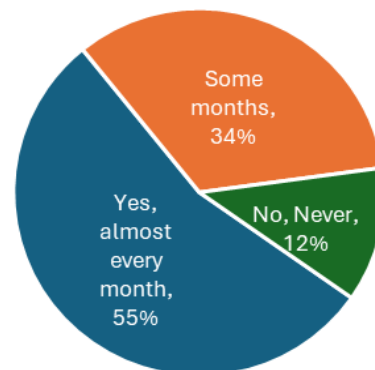
An evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program in Pangnirtung, which was released in May of 2025, reinforces the perspectives of key informants in our study. The first phase of that evaluation included a survey administered to 52 participants in the Hamlet Food Voucher program. The survey included questions about their food security before the Hamlet Food Voucher program began. As shown in the figures below, 88% of respondents reported that their children sometimes did not eat enough and 89% indicated that their children sometimes ate less healthy food because of financial difficulties prior to implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program.

Before the Hamlet Food Voucher Program:

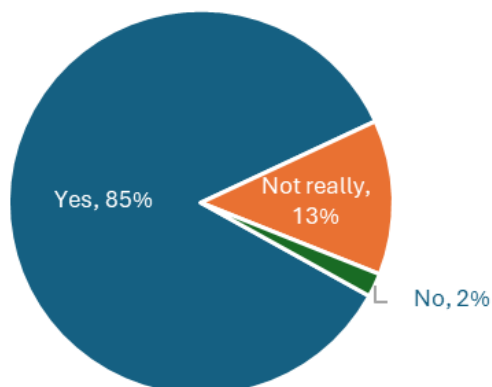
Were there times when the children in your care were **not eating enough** because there was not enough money?



Were there times when you could only feed your children **less healthy food** because you didn't have enough money to buy food?



The survey also asked about the impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program on their ability to feed children healthy food. As shown below, 85% responded that the program provided enough financial support to feed the children in their homes more healthy food.



Is the program providing **enough financial support** to feed the children in your household **more healthy foods**?

Multiple people also spoke of the reduction in burden on previously overwhelmed local services and supports. One person described the changes this way:

Before the introduction of the ICFI food voucher program, families struggled to access food for their children ... We have a food kitchen that the Hamlet helps financially ... They prepare some meals, and by the time it's like four o'clock, they ... [have] often exhausted its food supplies. However, since the CFI program launched, the soup kitchen now operates once a week, and still, leftovers are consistently available. [Before] there were a lot of people that posted on Facebook asking for help with food or if they can invite their children over for some meals. We've been seeing a lot of less of those posts.

Others noted that even organizations like Child and Family Services, whose missions were not explicitly food security related, previously took on responsibility for feeding people.

In my office, when I was with Family Services, we ran a food pantry basically off the side of our desk, because food insecurity was so high, and that doesn't exist anymore, because there's no longer that dire need, because people are getting food.

The Hamlet Food Voucher program freed these organizations to do more targeted work in line with their missions/mandates.

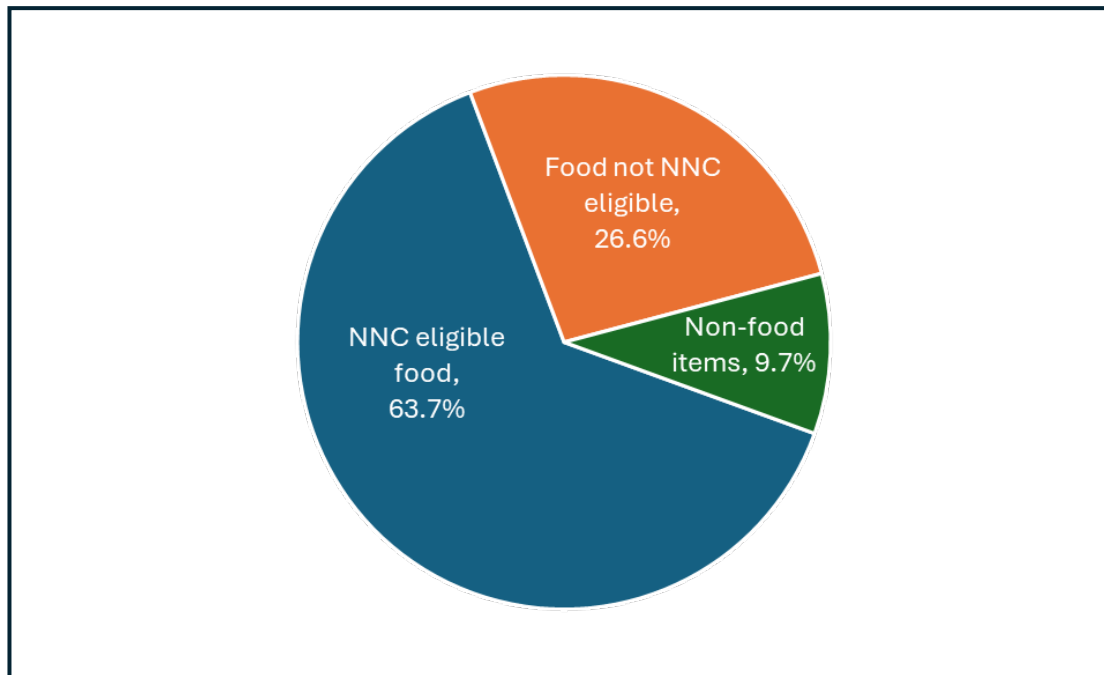
Purchase of healthy foods

Key informants also spoke of families buying healthier food. For instance, one Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO office employee pointed to the restrictions on food purchases in place in most hamlets, noting that people using Hamlet Food Vouchers were:

Only allowed to have nutritious food. We've been seeing a lot of people buying nutritious food, such as meats, vegetables, fruits for their children.

These qualitative accounts match data on the purchases made by individuals receiving grocery supports in Qikiqtaaluk, which, as summarized in Figure 7, shows that 64% of expenditures were on items that were considered "healthy" by NNC and, accordingly, qualified for air freight or surface subsidies. Only 27% of expenditures were for foods in

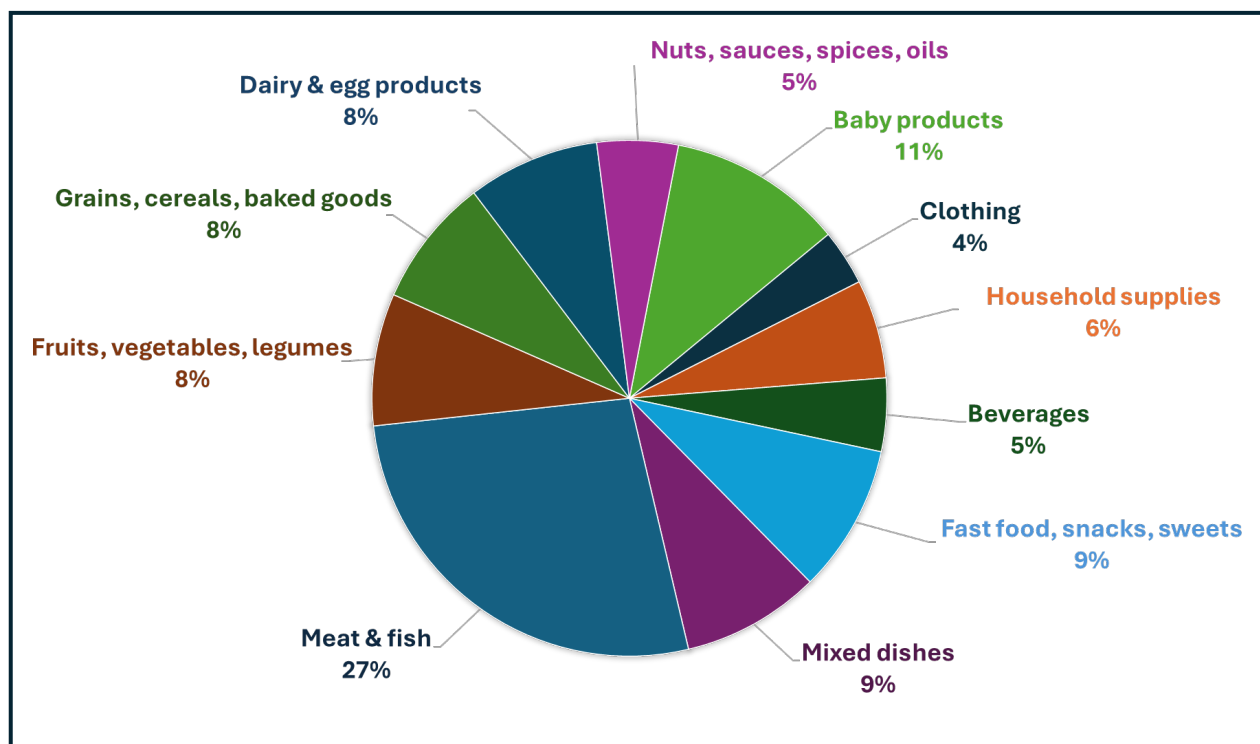
Figure 7: Expenditures on NNC and non-NNC eligible items by Qikiqtaaluk families using Grocery Supports



categories like (non-dairy/non-juice) beverages, sweets, snacks, mixed dishes and fast food that are usually ineligible for any type of subsidy.

Figure 8 gives a more detailed breakdown of grocery support purchases made by families in Qikiqtaaluk. It shows that 27% of expenditures were on meat; 59% were on other categories of food and drink. Only 9% were on fast food, snacks, or sweets; another 9% were on “mixed dishes” which includes a wide range of products from pizza to prepared salads with meat (the top four products in this category are pizza, fried chicken, corned beef hash, and Kraft Dinner). Beverages, excluding fruit/vegetables juices and milk, which are classified in separate categories, made up less than 5% of expenditures (the top four products in this category were drink crystals, coffee, fruit punch, and hot chocolate mix). The Baby products category includes formula, baby food, and diapers. The household supplies category contains cleaning and personal hygiene products as well as furniture and bedding (the top four products in this category are mattresses, toilet paper, bedding, and paper towels).

Figure 8: Expenditures on different categories of purchases by Qikiqtaaluk families using Grocery Supports



An important limitation of these data is that they only reflect purchases made with grocery supports, and do not reflect purchases made with personal income from other sources. For example, ISC prohibited the purchase of tobacco using food voucher funds, and most hamlets prohibited the purchase of items like pop and chips (see Chapter 4 for a discussion of these policies). Accordingly, they showed up minimally in the grocery supports data, but families could purchase such items using income from employment, alternate government programs (e.g. income support), or other sources.

Impacts of increased access to food

Existing research demonstrates that food insecurity has harmful, and sometimes lasting, impacts on children/youth. Systematic reviews and meta-analyses of existing research document strong associations between food insecurity and negative measures of children/youth's general health, mental health (depression and stress), academic performance, cognitive development, and specific health problems (such as asthma). The

adverse effects of food insecurity on young children can occur before clinical markers of food insecurity, such as being underweight, are easily identifiable, and can persist even after treatment. Infants and toddlers are particularly vulnerable, in part because they are completely dependent on adult caregivers whose mental health, energy levels, and engagement can also be affected by food insecurity.^{104,105,106,107,108,109,110,111}

In keeping with existing research, key informants described positive physical and social impacts for children receiving Hamlet Food Vouchers and for others in their communities. Several key informants noted improvements in school attendance and increased physical activity among children.^d The physical health impacts were even more pronounced for children who experienced severe food insecurity or had underlying health conditions.^e

For instance, one service provider spoke of a child who had lost a “considerable amount of weight.” They said:

It was clear ... in reviewing the history, that the child wasn't having enough to eat, would be skipping meals. We got grocery supports, and you could see on his growth curve that it went from a dip into back up. And so clearly there was, you know, like, substantial nutritional deficiency there that was rectified.

A service coordinator spoke of the case of a child who moved back and forth between the homes of more than one caregiver; her access to specialized nutritional products purchased with grocery supports depended on the home she was staying in. They noted:

When her grocery supports are provided, her glucose levels and range are stable, and her levels are constantly the same. When those items are not provided ... her

^d Communities could also apply for funding for school food programs through ICFI; at least 8 communities received funding for some form of school food program by 2024. Accordingly, in some communities, the benefits of the Hamlet Food Voucher program were amplified by ICFI funded school food programs. An ISC staff member working in the regional office noted that: “The kids are excited to come to school. Kids who would normally be missing [school], a lot, are not missing because they know they're going to get that breakfast there.”

^e Because of the severity of their cases, these children may have been receiving grocery supports prior to, instead of, or in addition to participating in the Hamlet Food Voucher program.

levels go down. When they're tested, they can see that her levels are not the same, and her physical health is drastically impacted when those grocery supports are not available to her.

A service coordinator/provider noted that the health benefits for children with underlying medical conditions extended beyond the direct impacts of more adequate nutrition. She said:

I've had lots of families come to me and say it's really been life changing in that they don't have to worry about food as much as they used to, so they're able to focus their attention on other things ... if you have a child with a medical condition, your priority is going to be to feed that child... if you don't have to worry about, you know, three meals a day, you can focus on other things, in particular, other aspects of health.

Beyond physical health

A service coordinator/provider spoke of positive impacts, extending beyond physical health, that were noticeable from the outset of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. She recalled the excitement in the community on day one of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, observing that the program made a difference by relieving people's stress. Another service coordinator/provider, who was also a food voucher recipient, spoke of the economic impact beyond just food purchases, including the ability to start saving and to enjoy modest leisure activities that were previously out of reach.

[We're] able to start saving and doing things that we enjoy, like going out for dinner or things like that, yeah, or going to the movie theater, which I haven't been able to go in years.

A grocery store manager/employee contextualized this further, describing the economic shift for families in a way that highlighted the Hamlet Food Voucher program as critical in allowing families to move beyond an overwhelming focus on basic physical needs and move towards centering personal growth and realizing their full potential.¹¹²

[Before, people] have their money just to survive. Now they have some money to express themselves, to enjoy themselves, and that's a good thing. We all need that.

While the Hamlet Food Voucher program and grocery supports were not sufficient to address underlying issues leading to the need for grocery supports, key informants discussed cases in which they provide families with the assistance needed to move out of precarious situations. A service provider spoke about one of these cases, which she described as a rare example. She said:

It happens where there are periods where temporary grocery support sort of gives you that relief, to be able to focus on things other than basic needs for your children. You can potentially apply for a job, potentially work on your housing application. Potentially pay down debts you may have accrued. So, there are examples where I think that temporary support helps people get out of a rut and then move into a period of stability.

Another service coordinator/provider connected the vouchers with a reduction of stress related to financial burden. They noted that this was particularly true for the parents of babies, for whom food vouchers reduced the stress associated with buying expensive items like formula and diapers. When asked to describe a family that might apply for individual grocery supports, they highlighted the links to other personal and interpersonal dynamics that were exacerbated by not being able to afford food. They spoke with us about a specific family and their situation before being connected to the Hamlet Food Voucher program:

There was a lot of domestic violence in the home because they're stressed out, and the parents aren't eating because they're like, well, we can't eat because the kids need to eat. And the mom had said to me that she wasn't sending the kids to school [which provided food] because she was so afraid they were going to tell the school that they're hungry, and that family services was going to get involved.

Later in the conversation, reflecting on the impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, they said:

[If] you can relieve the financial burden and the stress on some of these parents, then you eliminate some of the domestic violence, you eliminate some of the trauma ... it just it helps make an overall better-rounded family.

Another shared that a principal of a local school pointed to a similar effect on children and youth, they mentioned that:

They have seen near zero fighting since the Hamlet Food Voucher started, and more food programs have been have started in the school.

After the Hamlet Food Voucher program

In the months leading up to the end of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, key informants shared fears about how discontinuation would impact the community. A grocery store manager/employee said:

I'm afraid that we're going to cut it off. I'm afraid that the community will not take it well, or it will affect a lot ... especially to kids. Because, yeah, I see a lot of people relying on it and they need it.

A Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO employee added that the uncertainty itself was harmful, asking how families could plan appropriately if they did not know whether they would receive support after April 1. A service coordinator/provider shared her fears that the impact of program discontinuation would be more profound because, while the food voucher program was operating, people lost the habit of coping with hunger.

The situation before was dire in some ways, but people learned how to cope ... nobody starved to death, even though some were sick from not having enough food. But if this is withdrawn, it's not just going to be a dire situation. It's going to be a crisis. I think I can't see it going any other way.

This idea was echoed in the comments of an ISC staff member who said simply:

It's not that you get used to it, but ... it becomes a necessity. You're buying food.

Two months after the program's end, service coordinators and providers reported they were seeing the negative impacts of the Hamlet Food Voucher program's discontinuation. One offered an image of the current level of need:

I've definitely noticed a lot of families reaching out ... now that this food voucher program has ended, there is no more like, supports for their children. I've had some people sharing photos of ... empty cupboards and fridges because they have, you know, three to six kids who they need to support, and without that funding, a lot of families are definitely struggling.

People familiar with the limited hamlet-level food security efforts in the region noted increases in demand for their services and resumption of emergency food security supports that were not needed during the Hamlet Food Voucher program. Others remarked on the resumption of coping strategies that were not needed under the Hamlet Food Voucher program. A Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO employee noted:

We're seeing families going hungry. We especially see it on social media ... people asking for food, at least a meal for a day or two.

A service coordinator/provider added:

I've seen some people selling carvings or like sewing items like seal skin hair pins, seal skin mitts, anything that they have in their home.

Even those families that were relatively well off because they had members who were employed noted the negative impacts of the end of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. For example, one Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO employee shared:

My daughter loves fruits and vegetables. She did a challenge ... She started [in] December, so she dropped all the sugary stuff she was having, and went on with the

fruits and salad and healthier foods ... Even her weight went down, so she looks much healthier smoother skin. So, we're all missing that fruit and vegetable[s].

Thus, even for key informants who did not necessarily worry about going without food, the end of the Hamlet Food Voucher program meant an end to access to fresh foods that many living in southern Canada may be able to take for granted.

Chapter 3 - The Hamlet Food Voucher program and inflation

In this chapter, we draw on anonymized records of purchases made by families receiving individual grocery supports and other sources of available data on inflation to examine the impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program on grocery prices in Qikiqtaaluk. We compare inflation in the Qikiqtaaluk region with inflation in the rest of Canada from January 2022 to July 2024 and, within the limits of the available data, test to assess the impact of the Hamlet Food Voucher program on grocery prices. We find that:

- Due to higher inflation rates, there is a growing affordability gap when it comes to grocery prices in Qikiqtaaluk. The price of a basket of 21 popular food products in Qikiqtaaluk was already double (2.06 times) that in the rest of Canada in early 2022; by 2024 the cost in Qikiqtaaluk was 2.32 times higher than in the Rest of Canada. This difference is after accounting for the NNC food subsidy; without the federal subsidy food prices in Qikiqtaaluk would be even higher.
- Similar to the rest of Canada, inflation in Qikiqtaaluk was higher in the months *before* the Hamlet Food Voucher programs were implemented (2022 to mid-2023) than afterwards. Notably, inflation remained high in Qikiqtaaluk even as inflation rates for the rest of Canada returned to more normal levels (~2% a year) by 2024.
- Based on the timing of Hamlet Food Voucher adoption and differences in inflation across communities, it does not appear that the program resulted in grocery inflation in Qikiqtaaluk. The existing evidence suggests that, if the Hamlet Food Voucher program had any impact on grocery prices, it amounted to only small average price increases, in the range of 0-2%, in a context where average food prices rose by as much as 30% in 2.5 years in some communities.
- Our analyses are based on the cost of groceries purchased with ICFI grocery supports and, accordingly, we cannot fully rule out the possibility of inflation linked to the implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program for products not captured in our data. Key informant perceptions of price increases during the time that Hamlet Food Voucher programs were implemented might also reflect heightened sensitivity to prices because of the pronounced increase in prices in

2022-23, sharing of extreme prices through social networks and social media, or shifts in the products that families participating in the program were able to purchase.

To read about any of these topics in more detail, click on a link below.

Concerns about inflation

Existing knowledge base

Evidence from ICFI individual-level food voucher receipts

Overall inflation

Inflation for identical products

Inflation and price differences across communities

Association of Hamlet voucher conversions with price increases

Summary of detailed evidence and limitations of analysis

Reconciling ICFI findings with qualitative evidence

Concerns about inflation

At the end of 2024, leaders in Nunavut raised concerns about rising retail grocery prices. They wondered if this inflation could be tied to the implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program and called for an “audit” of retail prices.¹¹³ The expansion of ICFI supports for food security during the previous three years coincided with a major inflationary episode, raising natural questions about whether they were associated.^f Price increases caused by the voucher program would reduce the program’s positive impact by diminishing the increase in purchasing power offered by ICFI vouchers. In addition, they would be particularly harmful for households that did not have access to voucher supports, such as households of elders who were not primary caregivers to children. One key informant characterized increases in food prices this way:

Since last year, [or] a couple years ago, the food has been skyrocketing ... everything seems like going up, going up and up.

When asked about the cause of skyrocketing prices, he noted he was just reporting on rumors, but said:

Sometimes I hear it’s just because of the Jordan’s Principal [the Hamlet Food Voucher program] ... the price is being raised because of choice, wanting to make profits or something.

In this chapter, we first briefly summarize the existing knowledge base on inflation and food prices in Qikiqtaaluk and other regions of the country before turning to an analysis of prices recorded in the ICFI individual-level voucher receipt data. In the final section of this chapter, we then reconcile with community perceptions reflected in key informant interviews.

^f Existing literature suggests that programs that increase income/government benefits can produce small increases in grocery prices. For example, a recent study by Daley, Li and Watson (forthcoming) found that expansion of the Canada Child Benefit in 2016 led to small retail price increases in NNC eligible communities (including Nunavut).

Existing knowledge base

Prices for most products go up over time (inflation); the less common situation when prices decrease over time is called *deflation*. In this chapter, we talk about changes in prices in percentage terms; for example, 10% inflation from one time period to another means that, if a basket of goods cost \$1000 in the earlier time period, it would cost \$1100 (10% more) in the later time period. In the past few years, there have been periods of higher inflation for food (prices climbing rapidly), and lower inflation (prices still increasing, but slower). That is, even as we discuss higher vs. lower inflation in the coming sections, food prices continue to rise, and inflation in any given time period is added on top of inflation in previous periods.

For Qikiqtaaluk, Nunavut, and Inuit Nunangat, basic facts about food price inflation during the period of ICFI-funded food security supports are not known from official data. Statistics Canada, which calculates official inflation for Canada, only reports overall inflation for Iqaluit and does not report a separate food inflation measure.

Inflation in Canada: Food inflation in Canada began rising in 2021 and peaked around 12% in late 2022. Inflation fell over the course of 2023 and, by the beginning of 2024, stabilized at its more typical level of 2-3%. Because food price levels never fell (a fall in food price levels would correspond to deflation, or a negative inflation rate), the food purchasing power of a dollar remains substantially lower than it was in Canada five years ago. There is ongoing debate on the causes of this inflationary episode. Possibilities include supply-chain disruptions (disruptions in the network of companies that produce and deliver goods to retailers), the war in Ukraine, increases in government benefits and stimulus payments during the COVID-19 crisis, and labor, energy, and raw material shortages. There is also debate about the extent to which the high inflation was driven by higher profits versus higher costs along the supply chain.

Comparisons between Nunavut and other areas: Nutrition North Canada (NNC)^g publishes the price of a basket of 67 food products in the Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB) for many communities in Inuit Nunangat.^h Costing exercises conducted under the Food Mail program, in 2010, suggest RNFB prices for Qikiqtaaluk, Kitikmeot, and Kivalliq were 80-85% higher than prices in the Southern “entry-points” from which groceries were shipped under the Food Mail program (Ottawa, Edmonton, and Winnipeg respectively; authors’ calculations).^{114,115} The most recent NNC data, for March 2022, imply prices in Inuit Nunangat rose 7.3% compared to March 2021 (authors’ calculations based on 41 communities). There is substantial variation across regions (See Table 2). The average across Nunavut communities is 10.5%, higher than the national average food inflation during this period (7.9%). These data do not include the peak food inflation period in late 2022. The only recent data for Inuit Nunangat come from Nunavik, where a recent report on the cost-of-living includes data through the end of 2023. These data show an overall price increase of about 20% from January 2022 to December 2023, well above the 9% overall and 14.7% food price inflation recorded nationally during the same period.^{116,117}

Table 2: Food inflation by community, based on the Revised Northern Food Basket (RNFB)¹¹⁸

Region	Food Inflation (2021-2022)
Nunatsiavut	2.6%
Nunavik	3.3%
Iqaluit	3.7%
Rest of Qikiqtaaluk	9.5%
Kivalliq	11.0%
Kitikmeot	13.9%

Together, these government data show that food prices in Nunavut communities are more than double the Canadian average, and that higher inflation in Nunavut has caused the gap to worsen over the past 15 years.

^g NNC is a federal program that provides direct payments to retailers to subsidize the cost of food in remote northern communities. See Chapter 1, Textbox 1 for a description.

^h These data come from the Northwest Company, which has stores across Nunavut and the rest of Inuit Nunangat, and Stanton and FCNQ (which operate in Inuvialliut and Nunvik, respectively. Arctic Co-op, which has stores in Nunavut and other areas of Inuit Nunangat, is not included in these calculations.

Evidence from ICFI individual-level food voucher receipts

Given the lack of official data on grocery prices in Nunavut, data from the ICFI individual-level grocery supports in the Qikiqtaaluk region provide valuable insight into inflation trends during the recent high inflation period. These data record the price of 302,006 distinct items purchased by recipients of ICFI grocery supports, in 12 of 13 Qikiqtaaluk communities, between mid-2020 and the end of 2024. Receipts were collected and scanned, and a computer program recorded the date, price, quantity, location, and product description from each receipt on a spreadsheet that ISC made available to the research team.

Textbox 5: Limitations of the ICFI grocery support data

Our analysis of grocery prices in Qikiqtaaluk relies on data for purchases made using individual-level, ICFI funded grocery supports. While these data are the most complete source of Qikiqtaaluk specific food prices available to us, they have important limitations.

- Many important products are potentially excluded from the analysis because they were not purchased using ICFI individual-level food vouchers for a variety of reasons, including restrictions on what could be purchased. (As discussed in Chapter 4 of this report, these restrictions could differ across communities).
- Some Qikiqtaaluk communities are not well represented. There are no data for Resolute Bay; only 116 (0.04%) purchases from Grise Fiord and 1,171 (0.39%) from Kimmirut are observed in the data; only five communities make up over 70% of the sample (Iqaluit 23.5%, Kinngait 16.5%, Pangnirtung 12.8%, Igloolik 10.1%, Pond Inlet 9.9%).
- There are also very few transactions observed before 2022 (less than 0.26% of the sample), few transactions observed between March and December 2022 (1.1% of the sample), and very few transactions observed after June 2024 (only 0.72% of the sample). This means that there is also little or no data on the price impacts of the Hamlet Food Voucher program in communities that converted to the Hamlet-level voucher program after 2023 (this includes Kimmirut, Sanikiluaq, Igloolik, Arctic Bay, Hall Beach, Kinngait, and Iqaluit).
- Our analysis also largely reflects prices at the Northern stores, as less than 1% of the receipts we received are from Co-ops.

When we observe the same product sold in the same community at two different periods, we can calculate an inflation rate for that product and community; the data can also be used to compare prices across communities for the same product. The data provide insight into inflation during the period leading up to, during, and after adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program for several communities, and we are also able to match some individual products to national average product prices reported by Statistics Canada (although the latter does not report brands).

A weakness of these data is the lack of representativeness and missing data for certain periods and communities. In practice, our analysis of inflation largely reflects the price of the products purchased most frequently with ICFI individual-level vouchers, in Northern stores, and in the communities where more individuals received these vouchers. The products are mostly food but include some clothing, household supplies, and other baby products (see Figure 8, Chapter 2). The limitations of these data are detailed more fully in Textbox 5.

Overall inflation

Table 3 presents inflation estimates for all the prices reported in our sample of Qikiqtaaluk receipts, with a comparison to the Canadian Consumer Price Index for food purchased from stores (CPI), which tracks changes in the cost of a basket of food products over time. It also includes separate inflation rates for the five communities with the largest sample of receipts in the data set, and inflation rates for specific food categories. Prices for each product and community are averaged within each quarter. To construct a price index (a measure of how prices change over time), we weight each comparison of product prices within a community using the total quantity purchased in that community in our sample. This approximates the methodology used for the CPI; it gives more weight to price increases for products purchased in greater quantities. Conceptually this approach reflects the inflation rate for the goods purchased with ICFI vouchers.

We report inflation rates for the period for which we have a large sample of products and communities: the beginning of 2022 to mid-2024. We also provide a breakdown into the

Table 3: Inflation Rates calculated using ICFI individual-level voucher receipt data

	2022Q1-2024Q2	Before Hamlet Vouchers 2022Q1-2023Q2	Hamlet Voucher phase-in 2023Q2-2024Q2
Canada Food CPI	13.9%	11.1%	2.5%
Qikiqtaaluk	26.5%	17.4%	7.1%
Communities			
Iqaluit	30.2%	17.6%	8.1%
Kinngait	30.9%	21.3%	8.0%
Pangnirtung*	23.8%	10.5%	7.6%
Igloolik*	25.1%	13.9%	8.2%
Pond Inlet*	26.3%	18.0%	7.3%
Categories			
Baby products	23.0%	12.0%	8.3%
Beverages	26.8%	21.6%	8.4%
Dairy and egg products	27.4%	15.2%	6.8%
Fruits, vegetables, legumes	10.0%	8.4%	3.8%
Grains, cereals, baked products	33.0%	23.1%	8.8%
Meat and fish	20.0%	12.7%	6.6%

**Indicates community that had phased-in Hamlet Food Voucher program by 2024Q2. Note that columns 3 and 4 may not add up to column 2 because of differences in the set of products being compared. Canada Food CPI from StatsCan Table 18-10-0004-01.*

2022Q1-2023Q2, the period *before* the introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, and 2023Q2-2024Q2, the period during which most Qikiqtaaluk communities adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program. Table 3 shows that inflation rates for the products purchased with ICFI vouchers in Qikiqtaaluk were substantially higher than food inflation in the rest of Canada between 2022Q1 and 2024Q2. Inflation was close to double – more than 10 percentage points higher than – Canadian food inflation over the same period.

Inflation was concentrated during the period before Hamlet Food Vouchers were introduced, mirroring the pattern observed for Canadian food inflation as a whole. The level of “excess” Qikiqtaaluk inflation (the difference between inflation in Canada and Qikiqtaaluk) was larger during the earlier period (6.3%) but remained high in the later period

as well (4.6%). Across product categories, inflation was much higher in 2022Q1-2023Q2 than in 2023Q2-2024Q2.

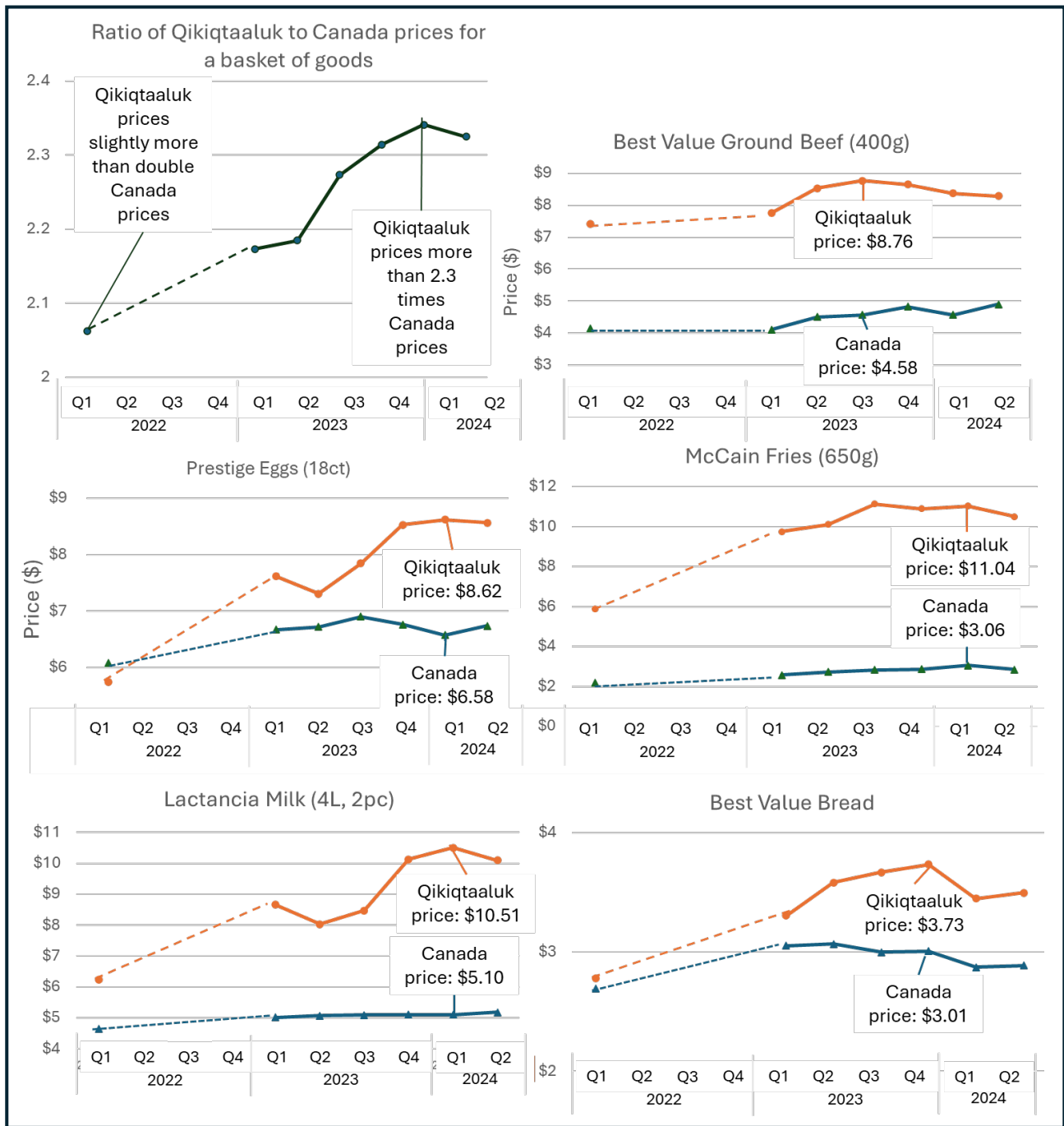
However, inflation rates differed across products, with lower inflation for fruits, vegetables, and meat products, and higher inflation for grains, cereals, dairy, and egg products. These differences in the products purchased could affect overall estimates of inflation. If, for example, people in Qikiqtaaluk purchased more high-inflation products (like grains, cereals, dairy, and eggs) than the Canadian population, this difference in product preferences would add to the excess inflation estimated for Qikiqtaaluk.

Inflation for identical products

The Canadian CPI for food purchased from stores measures inflation for a different set of products than the ICFI receipts. For greater comparability, we also analyzed a subset of 21 products that we can match to average Canadian prices. This also allows us to compare price levels directly.

The first graph in Figure 9 shows that the average price level for these 21 popular staple products in Qikiqtaaluk is much higher than in the rest of Canada and grew from about 2.06 times higher in early 2022 to about 2.32 times higher by mid-2024. The bulk of this increase occurred in the period before the end of 2023 and predated the introduction of Hamlet Food Voucher programs in most communities. This pattern is consistent across most of the 21 matched products, including the five we report in the additional graphs in Figure 9. Price gaps differed significantly across the products we compared for a variety of reasons, including subsidies and freight costs. For example, a dollar's worth of milk weighs much more than a dollar of eggs. Accordingly, when a per kilogram freight charge is added, it raises the price of milk in Qikiqtaaluk (relative to the South) by much more than the price of eggs.

Figure 9: Ratio of average Qikiqtaaluk prices to average Canadian prices for matched products. (2022Q2-Q4 interpolated due to limited data.)



Inflation and price differences across communities

The ICFI receipt data also allow for comparison of inflation and price levels across Qikiqtaaluk communities. Table 3 presents inflation rates by hamlet. Across communities, we observe a similar pattern: inflation was higher in the period before Hamlet Food Voucher program was introduced. However, there is also substantial variation across communities, particularly in the earlier period, before the introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. During the period of the Hamlet Food Voucher implementation, the two communities that had not implemented the program by mid-2024 (Iqaluit and Kinngait) had the highest overall inflation rates.

In terms of price levels, the most recently available data that allows for comparison of a similarly broad set of products come from the 2017 Nunavut Price Survey (approximately 250 products, all retailers). Table 4 reports the estimated price gap between other communities and Iqaluit using the ICFI receipt data and the earlier 2017 survey. Income buys substantially less food in communities outside Iqaluit, with approximately 9% higher

Table 4: Average price gap *relative to Iqaluit* for other Qikiqtaaluk communities

	2022Q1- 2024Q2 ICFI receipts	2017 Nunavut Price Survey mean
Arctic Bay	9.9%	9.8%
Kinngait	9.5%	7.2%
Clyde River	13.4%	12.1%
Grise Fiord*	23.5%	2.9%
Hall Beach	5.7%	4.9%
Igloolik	6.0%	10.7%
Kimmitut	7.7%	6.5%
Pangnirtung	12.8%	7.4%
Pond Inlet	8.5%	5.5%
Qikiqtarjuaq	13.9%	6.0%
Sanikiluaq	4.7%	7.4%
<i>Average (excl. Grise Fiord)</i>	<i>9.1%</i>	<i>8.0%</i>

**Most 2017 Nunavut Price Survey comparisons with Iqaluit involve around 250 products but only 86 are recorded for Grise Fiord. There are also not many receipts collected for Grise Fiord in the ICFI data. We exclude it from calculation of the average.*

average prices based on the ICFI receipt data. This is only slightly higher than the average we calculated from the 2017 Nunavut Price Survey.ⁱ

Association of Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption with price increases

The evidence presented in Table 3 and Figure 9 suggests that the adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program is unlikely to explain much of the inflation experienced in Qikiqtaaluk during the period represented in our ICFI data. While the data in Table 3 are consistent with some degree of “excess” inflation during the period of Hamlet Food Voucher adoption by most Qikiqtaaluk communities, they suggest that the overall contribution of the Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption to inflation in the last three years is likely to be modest compared to other factors. As seen in Table 3 and Figure 9, inflation was highest before Hamlet Food Vouchers were introduced. In addition, inflation was similar in communities that adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program and those communities that did not adopt the program during the time period covered in our data. Importantly, between mid-2023 and mid-2024, inflation in the two communities that had not implemented the Hamlet Food Voucher program by mid-2024 (Iqaluit and Kinngait) was similar to that in communities that had implemented the program (Pangnirtung, Igloolik, and Pond Inlet). This strongly suggests that factors other than the adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program contributed to the high inflation during this period.

We conducted a more formal econometric analysis of the ICFI Hamlet Food Voucher program that used communities that had not yet adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program as a comparison group. For example, if prices in a community that adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program rose by 10% from the quarter before program implementation to the quarter after implementation, but the prices in communities that did not adopt the program rose by 8% during the same period, we would only attribute 2% of the resulting price increase to the Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption.

ⁱ We also estimated price gaps from March 2022 NNC data; these are much smaller and likely reflect the importance of subsidies for the goods in the RNFB and the fact that NNC subsidies tend to be equalizing across communities (by design) relative to market freight costs.

Whether we considered adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program per se, or made adjustments for prior use of individual-level ICFI grocery supports and the number of children in the community (which impacts the change in income when the program is adopted), we found no statistically significant effect of the Hamlet Food Voucher program on grocery prices. Our analyses do not allow us to fully rule out the possibility that the program had *some* impact on prices, but any effect on prices was small: up to a ~2% additional price increase in the communities that had adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program compared to those that did not.

Figure 10: Change in prices (relative to 2023Q2) and Hamlet Food Voucher adoption (vertical line) in largest communities.

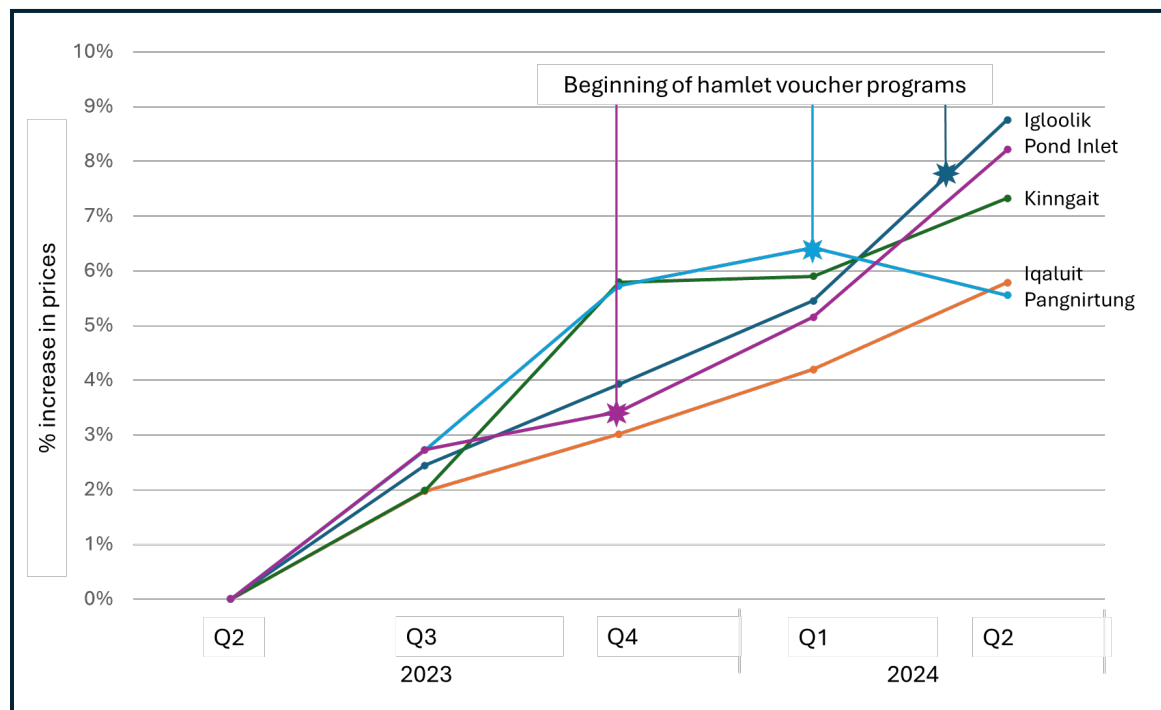
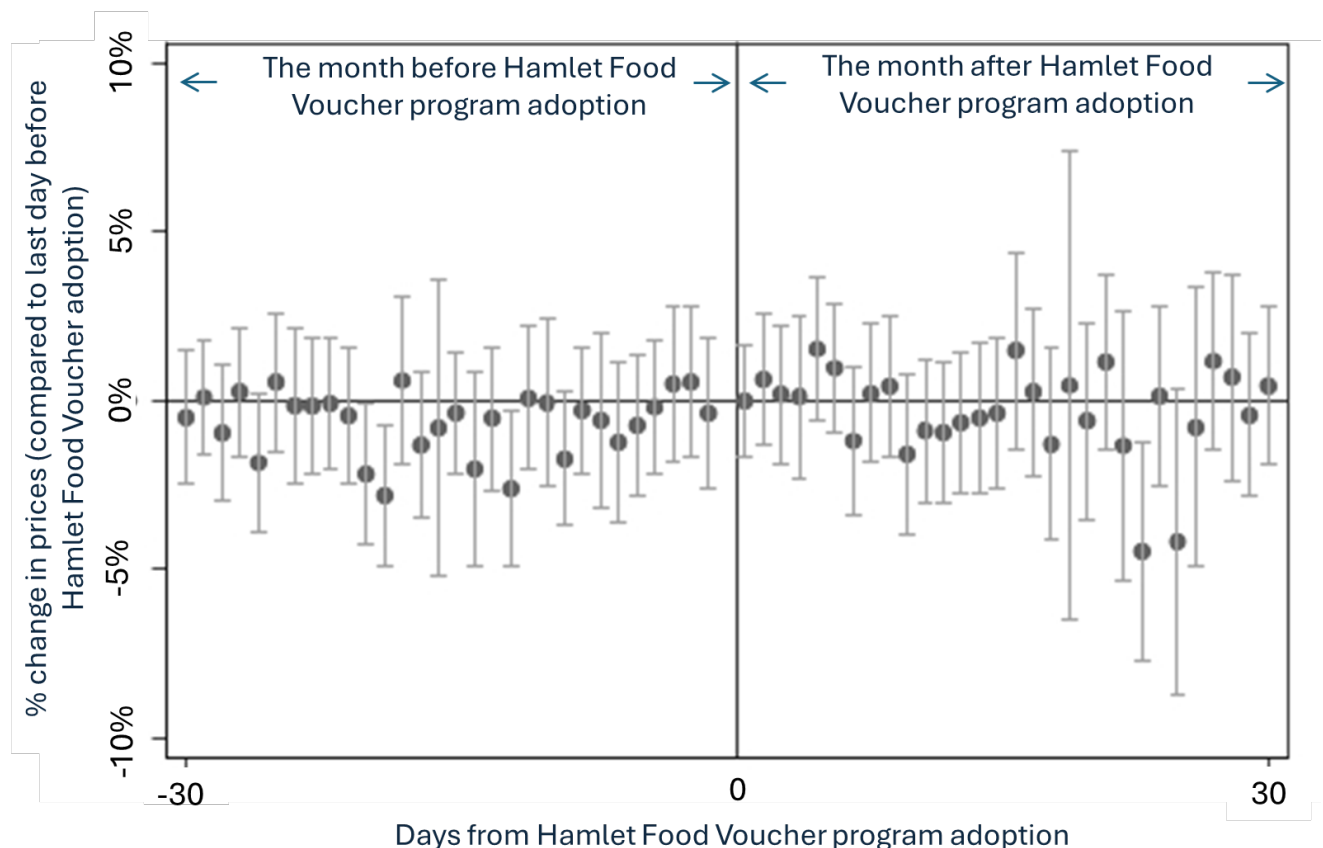


Figure 10 illustrates our analyses, explaining why we do not find a substantial effect of Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption on prices. It reinforces the findings of Table 3 and Figure 9. Figure 10 displays estimates of average price changes in the five communities with the most receipt data, relative to prices in 2023Q2. Price increases during the 2023Q2-2024Q2 period were fairly similar across communities, regardless of whether they adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program during this period. The data presented in Figure 10 also

indicate that the timing of price increases is not systematically related to the timing of voucher adoption.

Given that receipt data were collected daily, we can also zoom in on the precise timing of voucher adoption, under the assumption that vouchers become available on the 1st day of the month of adoption. For the communities that adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program by mid-2024, we compared prices in each of the 30 days before and 30 days after the adoption of the program to the prices on the last day before the program began. Figure 11 presents the results of this analysis, with price differences expressed in percentage terms. The analysis suggests that, on average, there were no large increases in prices in the 30 days before or after the adoption of the ICFI Hamlet Food Voucher program for the products purchased using vouchers. However, this analysis cannot rule out the possibility of Hamlet Food Voucher impacts on prices within a longer time frame.

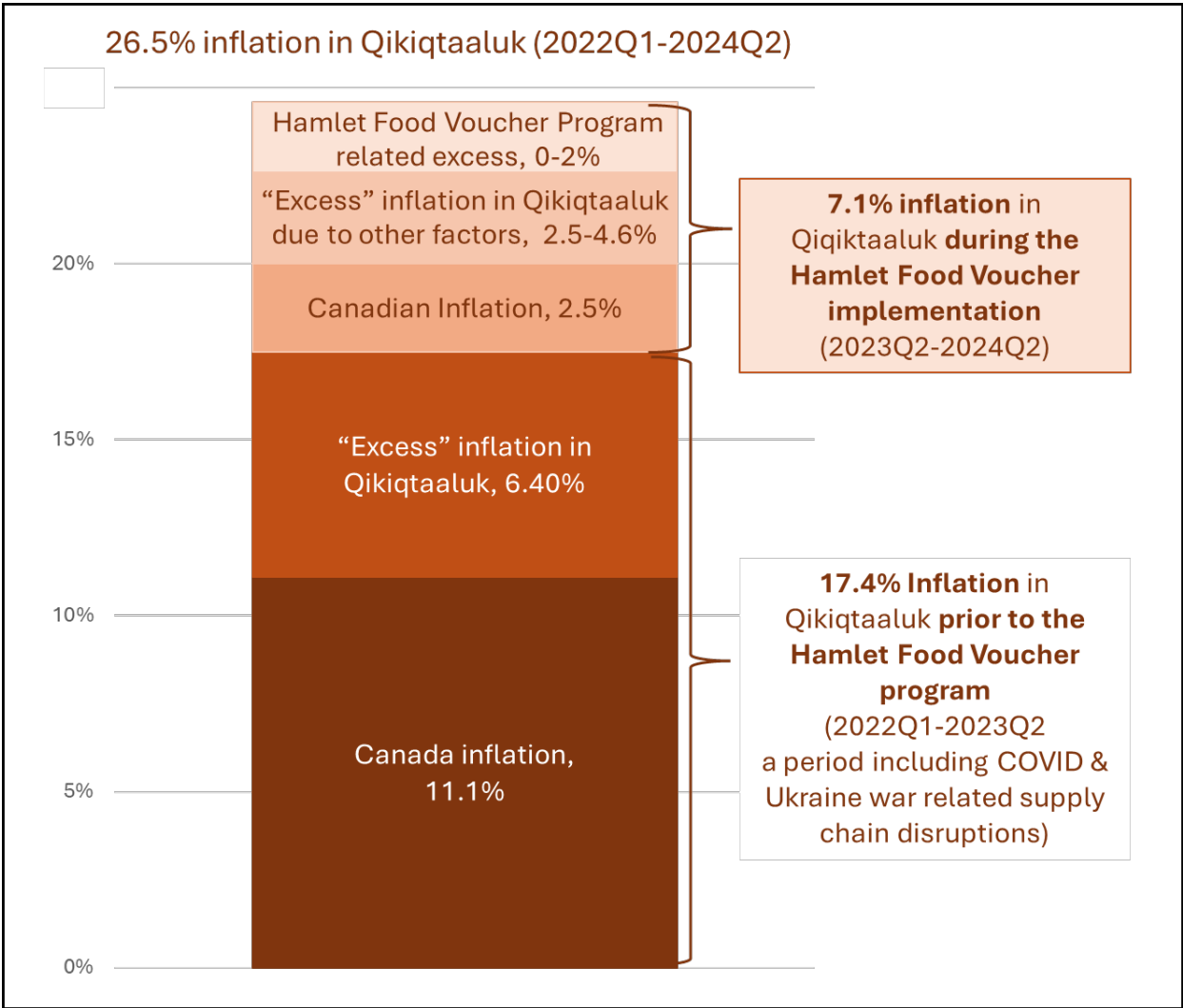
Figure 11: Estimated price differences in days before and after Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption (with 95% confidence intervals).



Summary of detailed evidence and limitations of analysis

Altogether, the available evidence suggests that the effects of adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program on the average price of products purchased with ICFI vouchers was small, at least over the period we can observe with our data. At most, it can only account for a small share of the inflation experienced in the region during this period. As displayed in Figure 12, inflation was much higher in the period before adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program than during the period in which the programs were being adopted.

Figure 12: A break-down of inflation in Qikiqtaaluk between 2022Q1 and 2024Q2



The total excess inflation (compared to average Canadian food inflation) during the period of Hamlet Food Voucher adoption (mid-2023 to mid-2024) was 4.6%, and this “excess” inflation was similar for communities, like Iqaluit and Kinngait, which did not adopt the Hamlet Food Voucher program until late 2024.

In the communities that adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program during the period represented in our data, there do not appear to be any large price increases in the 30 days before and after program adoption, and a more sophisticated econometric analysis that used variation in the timing of Hamlet Food Voucher adoption across communities suggests that causal effects of Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption are unlikely to exceed 2%. Thus, our analysis suggests that, at most, the Hamlet Food Voucher programs may be associated with between one-tenth and one-fifth of the 25-30% overall inflation rates we observed for products purchased with ICFI vouchers since 2022. A zero effect on average prices is also consistent with the available evidence.

With this said, it is important to return to the limitations of our analysis outlined in Textbox 5 (above). First, we observed almost no price data for Co-op stores. Second, we only observed the prices of products purchased with ICFI individual grocery supports. Unlike the standard CPI inflation measure, ICFI grocery purchases are not representative of all purchases. They were restricted to certain products, and if a price increased so much that no one bought the product using ICFI vouchers, we would not observe this price increase in our data. Third, we have limited data from after the Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption for some communities and none for others (like Iqaluit and Kinngait). Addressing these gaps in our analysis would require more recent receipt data and/or more comprehensive scanner data that could capture the universe of transactions and potentially shelf prices.

Textbox 6: Comparing ICFI findings to recent academic literature¹¹⁹

A recent academic study by Daley, Li, and Watson (forthcoming in the *Canadian Journal of Economics*) shows that an influx of cash can raise food prices in retail environments similar to that in Qikiqtaaluk. The study examines the effect of the 2016 introduction of the Canada Child Benefit, which raised the annual per capita income by an average of \$900 per capita (\$1,500 for the average tax-filer and \$6,000 for the average child benefit recipient), on prices in remote (Nutrition North Canada eligible) communities. The introduction of the Canada Child Benefit resulted in a modest increase in RNFB prices, about 1.2% on average, with a larger (3.2%) effect in communities with a retail monopoly. These price increases could be explained by increases in retail margins, but they could also be driven by increases in retailer costs. Retail cost increases are especially likely to result from unexpected surges in demand in an environment where many products are shipped once a year via cheaper sealift, based on an annual planning horizon, and need to be shipped by air when the sealift inventory is exhausted. The effect identified by Daley, Li, and Watson should be interpreted as a long-term effect driven by a policy that was anticipated and perceived to have durable political support.

The absolute scale of the ICFI Hamlet Food Voucher program is larger than the Canada Child Benefit expansion - \$6,000 a year per child, multiplied by the share of the Nunavut population under age 18, implies a \$2,300 per capita increase in income. However, the adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program was done on an ad hoc basis across communities, and it was difficult for retailers to anticipate the program's future. Uncertainty about the political support and durability of the program proved to be justified. Retailers had just experienced a period of high inflation for unrelated reasons in the period before the Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption, and there was a loss of income support (through the phasing out of COVID-19 benefits like CERB) in the period just before the adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. Unlike many of the Manitoba and Ontario communities served by Nutrition North Canada, most of the Qikiqtaaluk communities in our sample have two competing retailers (and of the three that do not, only Clyde River is served by the same retailer used in the earlier study, as Grise Fiord and Resolute are served by a Co-op). This combination of factors makes the estimates from the Canada Child Benefit Expansion less applicable, but if they did apply, extrapolating from those estimates would imply only a modest (~4%) contribution in a context where average food prices rose by as much as 30% in some communities.

Reconciling ICFI findings with qualitative evidence

The analyses of ICFI data presented in this chapter, the comparison to recent academic literature presented in Textbox 6, and evidence from past studies all suggest that policies/programs that provide families with extra money have, at most, a modest effect on inflation.^{120, 121, 122, 123, 124} Accordingly, it is important to understand why community members may have perceived a stronger association between adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program and price increases. There are at least four explanations that could reconcile the results of our quantitative analysis with local perceptions.

First, our analyses may have missed price increases that key informants and other residents of Nunavut communities experienced. Our data did not include the prices of all items available at stores in Qikiqtaaluk, we only observed the prices of items purchased with grocery supports. If the prices of some products skyrocketed – perhaps because sealift inventories were exhausted and retailers charged air freight prices – and, in response, people stopped buying those products, then price increases would not be observed in the receipt data.

Second, prices of products that are restricted by ICFI vouchers were not observed but may factor into perceptions of price increases. For example, beverages like pop (that are typically excluded from ICFI voucher and grocery support eligibility) might normally be brought in by sealift because they are heavy and shelf-stable. If families receiving support through the Hamlet Food Voucher program increased their purchases of pop using personal funds (from other income sources) and this exhausted sealift supplies, bringing in new supplies of pop by air could lead to large increases in prices. We could not observe the prices of these restricted goods with our data, but they likely factored into general perceptions of price increases.

Third, exceptionally high prices may be amplified by social networks and social media because they are extreme. This may lead to perceptions that extreme price increases are more common and typical than appears to be the case from our data. For example, when asked about grocery prices, key informants sometimes referenced people sharing

information about prices on Facebook. For example, a Hamlet Food Voucher program Coordinator/SAO office employee shared:

I was reading on social media from another community. I think it was in Grise Fiord, a person bought bananas, three of them ... And the total came up to over \$100 for bananas. So. And it was shared all around on social media.

Similarly, another key informant shared a story of a sharp increase in the price of a popular brand of yogurt:

There was a post on Facebook last week or the week before, where someone went in ... they had their receipt from buying their 12 pack of Yop, and ... it was \$33 ~ \$34 like, a couple weeks after when the program went in. So, there's a follow up to that by North Mart, where they said, Oh yeah, sorry, we made a mistake in pricing. People can get a rebate.

Fourth, given that there was unquestionably high inflation in the months leading up to the Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption, community members' perceptions of pricing may be partially based on price increases that occurred prior to the adoption of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. For example, some key informants shared community worries that price increases might be tied to the implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, but they also spoke of timelines for price increases in terms like "the last couple of years" that could include price increases that occurred prior to implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program.

It is also likely that, for some households, purchasing patterns changed due to ICFI Hamlet Food Vouchers and they bought foods, such as fruit, that they had not previously bought, or that they did not buy regularly before participating in the Hamlet Food Voucher program. Thus, some shoppers may have only "noticed" that prices increased when they had the money to buy these products, and may have made comparisons to the last time they purchased the product; in some cases, this may have been during the early pandemic period when there were other generous income supports like CERB.

Finally, key informant perceptions in some communities may reflect price increases that roughly overlap with the period of the Hamlet Food Voucher program implementation but may be related to other factors. For example, in a conversation with two key informants who worked in the same SAO office, one key informant noted that they saw prices rising since the introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. In response, the other key informant agreed, but attributed the price increase to errors in planning sealift orders. They described the situation this way:

I think it's gotten worse in terms of prices, because what happened is, you know, each year this food comes in on sealift around August. So, then we hear, 'Oh, they forgot to buy a lot of items,' or they, for whatever reason, didn't buy them. So, gradually they ran out of old stock, which was sealift, and then in come the new stock by air, and they mark that up by the same percentage. So, the prices have gone up, and that would probably be since we started Jordan's Principle ... to the point where it's become a community hullabaloo, let's say it's getting more and more airtime because people are not happy.

In this case, we cannot determine whether the shortage of sealift stock was an error that would have resulted in higher prices even in the absence of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, or if additional purchases enabled by the program contributed to the shortages. In either case, however, the pattern described extends beyond a simple scenario in which retailers raise prices to increase profits and points to the complex relationships between demand, freight costs, and grocery prices.

Chapter 4 - Learning from the Hamlet Food Voucher program

As discussed in Chapter 2, key informants praised the Hamlet Food Voucher program and detailed its many benefits. However, they also had suggestions for ways of improving the existing program. In this chapter, we discuss gaps, challenges, and ideas for innovation in the Hamlet Food Voucher program. We hope that this examination of the Hamlet Food Voucher program proves helpful in the design and implementation of future food security initiatives.

While key informants valued the Hamlet Food Voucher program and almost all wanted it to continue, they also called for an approach that better addressed the root causes of food insecurity in Nunavut. In keeping with Inuit plans for food sovereignty and poverty reduction, they called for more effective means of controlling prices, greater support for the harvesting and distribution of country foods, and a broader range of complementary services and supports to address mental health, education, and employment. When it came to the Hamlet Food Voucher program itself, they called for a less restrictive food security framework that allowed for the purchase of non-food necessities, extended to elders and other adults who were not primary caregivers for children, and reflected price variations across communities.

At the local level, Hamlet Food Voucher program coordinators and other SAO employees, as well as grocery store managers/employees and other community members, worked together to improve the program as much as possible within the framework presented to them. Over time, they:

- Experimented with the timing of fund release and the assignment of families to grocery stores to help families stretch their funds across the month and stabilize the food supply;
- Developed ways to enforce policies restricting purchases to “healthy” food that helped minimize tensions related to the exercise of control over community members’ purchases; and

- Generated ideas about ways to build on the Hamlet Food Voucher program by incorporating education related to budgeting and nutrition.

To read about any of these topics in more detail, click on a link below.

A more holistic approach to food security

Limitations of the hamlet food voucher framework

Restrictions on purchases

Exclusion of people

Sufficiency of voucher funding

Addressing challenges at the local level

Administrative decisions to help stretch funds and stabilize food supply

Ensuring the purchase of “healthy” foods

Education around budgeting/nutrition

A more holistic approach to food security

Food security is part of a complex web of challenges, tied to the ongoing impacts of colonialism, that are not addressed by the Hamlet Food Voucher program. As discussed in Chapter 1, these include, but are not limited to, the high cost of food, inadequacy of welfare supports, a housing crisis, precarious and limited employment opportunities, and severe deficits in the infrastructure across multiple domains.^{125, 126, 127, 128, 129} From this perspective, the Hamlet Food Voucher program addressed a pressing and critical need, but it did not address the root causes of food insecurity in Nunavut.

Figure 13: Eight long-term outcomes in the Makimaniq plan 2¹³⁰



Key informants noted that challenges for individual families may be compounded by gaps and challenges in existing income and food security related policies and systems. These include the ineffectiveness of Nutrition North Canada (NNC) in ensuring low grocery prices, the barriers to accessing country food, difficulties in obtaining birth certificates needed to access the child tax, insufficiency of income supports, and the precarity of employment opportunities in Nunavut. In addition, service coordinators/providers noted

that food security challenges faced by some families may be tied to mental health issues and the shortage of mental health supports.

ICFI is a temporary initiative put in place until a long-term, Inuit-specific framework can be developed and implemented. Existing Inuit frameworks, like the Makimaniq 2 Plan offer hope that this framework will take a more holistic approach to addressing the complex issues associated with food insecurity. The Makimaniq 2 poverty reduction strategy, which is summarized in Figure 13, proposed to treat food security as one of eight closely related outcomes that should be centered and achieved through a poverty reduction strategy.¹³¹

Another Inuit-specific framework is the Inuit Nunangat Food Security Strategy (INFSS) developed by Inuit Tapiriit Kanatami.¹³² The INFSS outlines the Inuit Nunangat food system, including country food and market foods purchased in commercial grocery stores. It identifies the main drivers of food insecurity in Inuit communities, such as poverty, environmental change, and diminished self-determination. Importantly, the INFSS outlines five key priority areas for addressing food insecurity, including: integrating Inuit-led food security and poverty reduction actions, creating sustained Inuit engagement on comprehensive legislated solutions, and building evidence-based programs and services.

Limitations of the Hamlet Food Voucher framework

While key informants spoke of the importance and benefits of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, they also identified key areas in which reform and revision might be useful. Their concerns clustered around three major themes: 1) the restriction of items that could be purchased through the Hamlet Food Voucher program, 2) the exclusion of some groups of people from the food voucher program, and 3) the sufficiency of Hamlet Food Voucher funding.

Textbox 7: A focus on country food^{133, 134}

In line with Inuit-specific food security frameworks, several key informants called for ICFI to support greater access to country food. For example, one person working with the Hamlet Food Voucher program pointed to restrictions on hunting caribou and called for the program to be expanded to include country food. She said:

If we can buy country food would be awesome, like caribou meat. We can only hunt those in the summertime with a quota. ... Not all families get caribou meat, but the meat is constantly shared ... with families, upon families. So, we want, they wanted, to see more country food that could be bought from this Jordan's Principle [ICFI] food voucher instead of just the stores.

Another Hamlet Food Voucher program coordinator/SAO office employee detailed some of the factors that make accessing country food difficult and called for strategies that better facilitate collective access to country food.

if people want to access traditional food, there are costs ... The people who can afford to have ski doo and go hunting and buy ammunition are the ones who are working and might only hunt on the weekends or take holidays ... I really like the idea of a hunting economy. Like, why not? Why don't we give every community a couple of full-time positions for hunters who can go get food and bring it back?

Other key informants also noted that practices around sharing of country food meant that increased access benefited the broader community.

An evaluation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program in Pangnirtung asked participants specifically about country food access and, similar to our study, found community members had a strong desire for greater access to country food. They suggested ways that access could be better supported through the Hamlet Food Voucher program, but also indicated that this would be a temporary, or 'band-aid' solution that did not address the need for more comprehensive reforms to improve the country food supply and distribution.

Indeed, because the Hamlet Food Voucher program relied on partnerships with grocery stores, which mediated distribution of voucher funding, they can be seen as reinforcing colonial patterns and existing corporate monopolies. The dominant corporate player in Nunavut is The North West Company, which operates two grocery store chains — "Northern" and "North Mart"— in 120 remote communities. With origins in an 18th-century fur trading business, the company has grown into a multi-billion-dollar enterprise and functions as a monopoly in 54% of the Northern communities where it operates.

Restrictions on purchases

ISC guidelines place some restrictions on what people could buy with ICFI grocery supports or Hamlet Food Vouchers. An ISC staff member working in the regional office explained those restrictions. Noting that local stores sell “everything”, they said:

We request that it be healthy food choices for children. But we don’t really limit what it is, as long as it’s food ... hopefully not coffee, no cigarettes or tobacco products, ... not skidoo parts or whatever else they sell in the Northern stores.

These restrictions may seem straightforward, and in line with a focus on food security, but some key informants spoke of negative impacts of the exclusion of all non-food items. One asked, for example, why the funds couldn’t be used to purchase feminine hygiene products, which are needed by youth and are sold at the grocery store. Others asked similar questions about clothing, cleaning supplies, and other essential items.^j

In a context in which country food traditions coexist with a retail food economy, restrictions on non-food items like bullets, skidoo parts, and other items used in hunting, fishing, and harvesting activities that provide families with culturally appropriate, nutrient-dense food are also potentially limiting restrictions. These restrictions have a historical analogue to the first Family Allowances introduced in Canada in the 1940s and 1950s; families in many Indigenous communities did not receive cash and could only purchase prescribed retail foods rather than hunting supplies.¹³⁵

An ISC staff member working in the regional office explained these restrictions, pointing out that families could put in separate requests for ICFI support to purchase non-food items that were required to meet their children’s needs. But these separate requests come at a cost: In addition to the family and service provider time needed to make a request, ISC employees must spend time adjudicating the request. Working in the southern context, the First Nations Child and Family Caring Society recently estimated the cost of adjudicating a

^j As seen in Figure 8 (Chapter 2), despite the general restriction on purchase of non-food items, purchases of some non-food essentials did sometimes occur.

Jordan's Principle request to be \$540, bringing into question the fiscal benefit of requiring separate requests for low-cost non-food items.¹³⁶

Exclusion of people

Other key informants spoke of the exclusion of entire categories of people from the Hamlet Food Voucher program. For example, one ISC staff member working in the regional office noted that, because ICFI's mandate is to meet the needs of Inuit *children*, the Hamlet Food Voucher program left some groups of people without supports that would facilitate greater food security. They noted that the program was inequitable for many seniors and other people who do not have primary responsibility for the care of children. Another key informant wondered if the families of non-Inuit children living in the region also struggled to manage high grocery prices. A Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO office employee shared some of their experience with people who are excluded from the Hamlet Food Voucher program:

I still get people that come here to try and register, even if they have no children, so I would have to explain to them that it's for people who have children under the age of 19. They're thankful, but some ask me why it's only for children.

Some key informants also expressed worries that those excluded from the Hamlet Food Voucher program experienced added food insecurity because of market shifts related to the Hamlet Food Voucher program. Some worried that people who were not primary caregivers for children faced increased prices because of the Hamlet Food Voucher program. However, as discussed in Chapter 3, the Hamlet Food Voucher does not appear to have significantly contributed to food price inflation. As discussed in more detail later in this chapter, others worried that people who could not participate in the Hamlet Food Voucher program had to contend with more inconsistency in food supply. A Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO office employee described their concerns this way:

All of a sudden, there's all this extra money in the community going out. ... we're talking and working with the stores, because I want to make sure that elders who do

not have children in their house and don't benefit from this program still have the ability to buy what they need at the store, and we don't put added stress on them.

Sufficiency of voucher funding

Finally, several key informants discussed concerns about the sufficiency of Hamlet Food Voucher program. Recipients received \$500 per child, per month, the same amount available to First Nations families in southern provinces like Alberta.¹³⁷ All key informants noted that this amount was helpful for families, but several also said that it was not sufficient to meet the needs of all families in all communities. One service provider/coordinator used Grise Fiord, the northernmost community in Qikiqtaaluk, as an example of a community in which Hamlet Food Voucher funding was insufficient.

It depends on your community, honestly. For example, Grise Fiord [is] the most northern community in Nunavut; it is not enough. \$500 does not meet the need for a child in Grise.

They compared conditions in Grise Fiord to those in Iqaluit, noting that:

[Families in Iqaluit] have multiple grocery stores, multiple different options available. So, there's competition between the grocery stores, as well, for lower prices. But then you're in Grise, you have one store ... that's your only option. Stock is low and the cost to fly to Grise Fiord is very different than Iqaluit. So, you're getting those shipping costs of things go on top of your price of items in certain communities.

Other key informants, who had lived or worked in multiple communities, also noted that the prices varied greatly between communities, and \$500 went less far if you were purchasing food in a community with high prices. (See Table 4, in Chapter 3, for an estimate of this variation.)

Some key informants pointed to variations in the sufficiency of the \$500 per child hamlet voucher payment, even within a hamlet. For example, multiple people suggested that this payment was not sufficient for families on income assistance. One key informant said:

[People] on income assistance are more likely to run out of food, even with the food voucher that is going out each month, due to the high cost of food prices.

They noted that sharing of resources within family networks “balanced out” situations in which some family members were still struggling.

If I was working, and for example, my sister is on income assistance, she’ll ask me if I have this just until next week, because the ends don’t meet.

Similarly, another key informant discussed the ways that other expenses - like housing - and sharing across family networks affected the sufficiency of the food vouchers. She acknowledged that, as someone who was employed, her situation was better than that of families that were surviving on income assistance, but also shared that, as the primary income provider for a household of five adults, she struggled to make ends meet even with ICFI support.

I am a single mother, so it’s a lot harder when you know rent is \$3,500 and groceries is \$500 a month for just one child, because I try to ensure that I have my child’s ...food and snacks, and then trying to afford to feed five adults will be difficult.

Thus, though the official goal of the Hamlet Food Voucher program was to support the purchase of nutritious foods for Inuit children, the reality was that recipients had much more to consider than simply feeding their children; they were working to cover multiple necessary expenses while also addressing the needs of their extended family and community networks. Indeed, a survey of 78 people participating in the Pangnirtung Hamlet Food Voucher program found that, while a greater proportion of participants reported they were always or almost always able to pay all their bills once the program started (58% during the program vs. 38% before), more than 40% of respondents were still only “sometimes or never able to pay all their bills”.¹³⁸

This struggle to make ends meet, even when participating in the Hamlet Food Voucher program, reinforces key informants’ concerns about the limitations on Hamlet Food Voucher purchases. It also provides important context for key informants’ mentions, and

reports in news outlets,¹³⁹ of some instances of families selling groceries, which may have been purchased with food voucher funds, on Facebook. Reselling of groceries is an adaptive response to the combination of insufficient funding and limited flexibility in the use of funds; it effectively converts Hamlet Food Voucher funding to a less restrictive and more flexible form of needed income support.

Addressing challenges at the local level

As discussed in Chapter 1, the Hamlet Food Voucher program emerged organically, in response to the combined urgency generated by pressure for a quick roll-out and the severity of food insecurity among Nunavut households.¹⁴⁰ A southern service coordination organization supported the development of an initial ‘group request’ to fund the program in one hamlet and applications in other hamlets built on that initial application. However, the parameters of the proposals to ISC were broad, and key details of the program that needed to be put in place were undefined. At the local hamlet level, Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators/SAO office employees, grocery store employees, service providers/coordinators, and other community members worked within the federally prescribed framework and the constraints of hamlet-level resources to address challenges and ensure that the program worked effectively. They:

- Innovated and experimented with administrative decisions around things like the timing of fund release and the assignment of families to grocery stores to help families stretch their funds across the month and stabilize the food supply.
- Designed and implemented rules and systems for enforcing rules to ensure the purchase of “healthy” foods.
- Imagined different approaches to education around budgeting and nutrition that might help families stretch their funds further while purchasing healthy foods.

These initiatives took time and energy to develop and implement. In addition, the introduction of rules and practices intended to ensure that families purchased ‘healthy’ food also required Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators and grocery store employees to

monitor families' purchases and, in some cases, to assert control over their purchasing decisions. These monitoring activities and efforts to minimize tension around monitoring and control required additional time and energy at the hamlet level.

Administrative decisions to help stretch funds and stabilize food supply

In keeping with ISC's framing of the Hamlet Food Voucher program as providing \$500 per child, *per month*, the default in most communities appears to have been monthly disbursement of Hamlet Food Voucher funding, on a single day, to all families. A service provider/coordinator discussed the challenge that monthly fund disbursement posed for families. Under conditions of high grocery prices and limited resources, she noted families could get stuck in a cyclical pattern that compromised food security.

I think a lot of people are buying a whole bunch of groceries at once, because now they haven't, maybe had food ... for the last couple of weeks. So, they spend a paycheck on it, but then, you know, their kids have friends over, or everybody just kind of eats it up right away.

This meant that they were, again, short on food at the end of the month, and the cycle continued.

A Hamlet Food Voucher program coordinator/SAO office employee described the impact of the release of monthly Hamlet Food Voucher program payments on the broader community.

We have put it out there several times to the community that, you know, the money is there for the entire month. You do not need to spend it all at once. ... But it tends to be, [they're] at the store to buy everything and then it leads to empty shelves, empty produce, and other people who aren't getting that [the vouchers] being affected by it. So, it's a big demand on the stores and the community in general sometimes.

The impact was heightened when it coincided with disruptions in food supply, for example, when flights carrying groceries were cancelled because of bad weather.

In this context, some hamlets revised their approach to fund disbursement. For example, one Hamlet Food Voucher program coordinator/SAO office employee shared that she started releasing Hamlet Food Voucher funds on a rolling basis throughout the month. Each day, she posted the names of 15-18 people whose funds would be released the next day on Facebook. Another coordinator said that she revised the timing of payments in her community, releasing funds bi-monthly, rather than monthly. She noted that this helped to counteract negative community impacts while also helping families stretch their budget to last throughout the month.

Changes in the administration of Hamlet Food Voucher funds had implications for Hamlet Food Voucher program coordinator workloads and, accordingly, decisions around disbursement were partially shaped by human resource capacity. Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators were responsible for reconciling accounts before releasing additional funds and, as discussed in more detail below, most also had responsibility for reviewing purchases to ensure they complied with program guidelines. Strategies like releasing funds on a rolling basis helped program coordinators manage their workloads by spreading it out across the month, whereas a strategy of releasing twice a month, or more frequently, could come with added work.

Considerations of coordinator workload were also among the complex factors that influenced administrative decisions around flexibility for families to shop at multiple stores. Key informants recognized the importance and value of consumer choice, citing the variety and quality of products, the ability to purchase at lower prices, and even relationships with store employees as reasons that a family might wish to shop at one store over another at any given time. However, across hamlets, key informants noted the heavy administrative burden associated with “switching” a family from one store to another and shared restrictions they put in place to limit that burden. One Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator/SAO office employee explained it this way:

We’ve had it where they’re able to change [stores]. However, we are not able to maintain that. So, we have now gone to whatever store you’re registered at is the

store you're staying at, because ... some people would change every single month, and the workload behind that is just too much.

In all the hamlets in which we spoke with key informants, the Hamlet Food Voucher programs were reliant on information provided by grocery stores to track family spending: families either received store gift cards charged with their monthly amount or had a store account that they used for food voucher purchases. In hamlets with multiple stores (most often a North Mart/Northern and an Arctic Co-op), each store kept separate accounts. This meant that, for a family to shop at two (or more, in Iqaluit) stores within a month, the Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator had to assume responsibility for working with stores to establish accounts and track families' spending across stores in real time. Accordingly, all hamlets in which we spoke with key informants required participants to wait until their next disbursement to switch stores, and several restricted the number of these switches to one or two a year.

Iqaluit, which has several (6-10) stores, has to manage the most complex arrangements. A service provider/coordinator supporting the development of the Hamlet Food Voucher program in Iqaluit described the evolution of the approach there.

They [the hamlet] wanted to be fair to all businesses ... their initial idea was, do all those vendors, do unlimited switching. So, you could switch at any time between the vendors. Do unlimited customization in terms of how much funding that you do between the vendors. So, for example, you could spend ... \$100 a month at Northern and then your remaining \$400 at Ventures. And then you can swap at any time.

Based on experience in other hamlets that started their Hamlet Food Voucher programs earlier, they recommended

Keep it simple ... minimize the number of swaps to once a month. People have a swap day, and they have to stick to it for the month, and do not divide up amounts between vendors. If people are unhappy with North Mart one month, they can switch to Ventures the next month, but do not allow them to give five cents here and five cents there.

With similar considerations in mind, one hamlet decided to disburse funds every two weeks *and* rotate families between grocery stores. They divided the list of food voucher recipients by last name and assigned half to the Northern grocery store and the other half to the Co-Op for the first payment of the month; they switched stores for the second half of their monthly funds. The Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator explained why they did this:

The food prices are ridiculously high, so we don't want it going all at once, so we decided to split it in half and on each month, if you got it from Co Op, and on the second one, and you'll get it from the Northern, it's switching. We don't want them shopping in one store, because it's going to run out of whatever they have, because of many families do their shopping here and there. So, we decided to split them up and ... they have more choices.

Ensuring the purchase of “healthy” foods

Another significant aspect of hamlet-level work had to do with policies restricting purchases to ensure that families used Hamlet Food Voucher funding for “healthy” foods. The mandate for these policies was unclear. ISC may initially have played a role in establishing expectations that hamlets impose such restrictions. However, by the time of our interviews, ISC only restricted the purchases of non-food items and items for adult use (such as cigarettes); all food items were allowed under ISC guidelines. An ISC staff member explained:

At the beginning, we used to say no junk food, but we were asked to take that out, because who are we to judge what people should feed their children?

Similarly, a service coordinator/provider supporting the development of a Hamlet Food Voucher program recalled that the hamlet had an interest in promoting healthy food purchases and described their initial plans this way:

We had an initial aspiration that healthy foods, only healthy foods, would be accessed through the Hamlet Food Voucher program, and that we, you know, we thought maybe an easy way to do that would be to allow only NNC subsidized items

to be purchased ... it's not a perfect measure of health, but it does exclude massive categories of things like pop ... It would be easy, because all of the NNC subsidized items are marked in the grocery store ... usually with a green sticker.

They shared that there were challenges in communicating these expectations to families, and complaints about the restrictions that were communicated. After reviewing receipts from initial purchases, they realized that restricting purchases to NNC subsidized foods would “be a massive behavior change intervention.” Thus, the service coordinator/provider’s understanding was that the hamlet shifted to simply restricting purchases to food. Still, when interviewed more than six months after the start of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, the coordinator in that community shared that their program restricted purchases of “junk food” and detailed a complex system for ensuring compliance with this rule.

Indeed, though key informants mentioned at least one hamlet in which they believed there were no additional restrictions imposed on the purchase of food items, all the hamlets in which we talked to people had additional restrictions in place. These restrictions were broadly described as “no junk food” and the examples people gave included chips, soda, chocolate, and prepared foods.

Key informants broadly indicated support for restrictions that might help ensure children were eating healthy food, but they also described tensions and added work associated with the enforcement of these restrictions. Several key informants shared initial difficulties in ensuring that families understood the hamlet-level restrictions. One sought to overcome this by creating a Facebook group where she could post information about what people could purchase with the food voucher funds and what they could not. Other strategies included hanging posters in the local grocery stores and/or talking with individual people about restrictions each time they purchased a restricted item.

In some hamlets, store cashiers also had a role to play. One Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator noted:

The cashiers, they check the items they're buying ... They usually [do] not let them buy it. Cashiers are usually helping too.

Thus, grocery store cashiers in some hamlets were informally charged with mediating hamlet-level restrictions and informing families of what they could or could not buy. A grocery store manager/employee in another hamlet noted that this could be stressful for cashiers. She highlighted the importance of being able to defer to the hamlet when it came to the rules around what could or could not be purchased.

The cashiers know what, basically, what they should have and not have. But cashiers are young. They're nervous ... the administrative body is not the cashier. They'll call out to me. I have learned to say, 'You need to check with the hamlet. We have a list. If it's not defined in your list, then you need to check with the hamlet. And you're better off no until you do.'

She expanded on this, explaining:

It's a local to a local. And you know, that's very different, very, very hard to do at times. So, this one takes the guesswork out of it. Yeah, they know they're being looked at, they're being checked on, and the food actually goes to the child or the family.

In mentioning that families know "they're being looked at", she referenced the work that Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators did to ensure compliance with hamlet-level restrictions. They regularly reviewed receipts for each participant to identify restricted items and calculate the associated expenditures. In some hamlets, the coordinator simply reached out and talked with families that purchased restricted products, clarifying and reminding them of the restrictions. In other places, funds spent on restricted items were deducted from next month's allocation. In still others, participants were asked to come to the hamlet office and repay the amount before they could receive additional funds. Key informants noted that the burden of enforcement was heaviest in the early days of program implementation; the number of restricted items being purchased declined over time. One

Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator noted that the reduction was so pronounced that she shifted from full review of the receipts to simply spot checking.

Textbox 8: Scrutiny of purchases alongside budgeting and nutrition knowledge: Lessons from recent research in Kitikmeot ^{141,142,143}

In an ongoing study of the impact of federal food security supports, researchers interviewed 24 members of a Kitikmeot community about their day-to-day challenges feeding their families. In conversation, respondents frequently mentioned concern that their purchases were scrutinized to ensure they were in compliance with the Hamlet Food Voucher program expectations. Respondents expressed twofold concerns about the monitoring of grocery receipts: first, that their own family's benefits would be withdrawn if they failed to comply with program requirements; second, that the withdrawal of benefits would impact others, worsening hardship for their own and other communities. It is notable that the expectation of scrutiny extended beyond just Hamlet Food Vouchers. Many study respondents who were provided with store gift cards in recognition of their participation asked the researcher if there were restrictions on how store card funds could be used (there were no restrictions). It is clear that current processes around ICFI fund distribution have created an atmosphere in which recipients expect to have their behavior monitored.

This atmosphere exists despite the fact that many respondents demonstrated considerable knowledge about budgeting, meal planning, and nutrition. Respondents reported the use of many strategies to make limited funds go as far as possible to purchase nutritious food and prepare nutritious meals for their extended families. These strategies included: reserving a portion of funds for the following week, checking prices at the two local stores prior to purchasing items, making their own bread, cooking soups or stews that use available protein and vegetables efficiently, storing portions carefully in the freezer for future use, and adding country foods like fish and caribou whenever possible to enhance the nutritional quality of meals. While knowledge of budgeting and nutrition could be improved by more education (just as it could in southern communities), it is clear that there is already a considerable core of knowledge on these topics in Nunavut communities.

Education around budgeting/nutrition

Finally, though few key informants had an opportunity to implement them, many shared ideas for education, particularly around budgeting and nutrition, that might help families

make the most of the Hamlet Food Voucher funds. A service provider/coordinator grounded her perspective on the need for education around these issues in an understanding of the fact that the Hamlet Food Voucher program allowed many families in Qikiqtaaluk to shop in a new way, which involved choices and possibilities that had not previously been available to them.

People are not used to having the ability to do grocery shopping ... What is healthy for their children to eat is not always something that people are aware of, because they've never had the ability to do that before ... people aren't aware how to budget.

She suggested that some families might buy less healthy, lower-cost foods because that's all that they had been able to afford in the past and what they were accustomed to purchasing.

While agreeing on the importance of education around budgeting and nutrition, a grocery store manager/employee noted that, because of Nutrition North subsidies, healthy foods could be more affordable than other foods.

We also have Nutrition North program, which makes their milk and produce and vegetables much more competitive. It's lower here than ... Newfoundland, by far ... It is a myth that those produce and vegetables and things on the Nutrition North list are more expensive because they are not.

Information about Nutrition North was among the things that this key informant suggested covering in an education initiative.

A service provider/coordinator in another hamlet agreed that education was a missing component of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, but she also noted that education about budgeting had to be carefully designed to complement the emphasis on food sharing and supporting community members, which are strengths of Inuit culture. She said:

I love how here, when people do go hunting, they'll often go on the radio and say, "If anybody wants fish, or seal, or whatever it is ... muktuk. There's some at my house. Come and get some. Bring a bag" ... I love that caring for one another that way, and I

wouldn't want to see somebody pick up the principles of budgeting and decide that they can't share because they've got to make this last for three months or something.

Other suggestions included sharing multiple recipes using a fresh/seasonal ingredient in stock at the grocery store to help people avoid food waste, distributing information about the price of cooking healthy meals from scratch (in comparison to buying prepared meals), and building on existing communal knowledge by sharing food samples and recipes to generate excitement about trying new, healthy foods.

Appendix 1: Methods

In this report, we share preliminary findings from a multidisciplinary, mixed-methods study that started as an evaluation of individual requests for grocery supports in Qikiqtaaluk and evolved as the Hamlet Food Voucher programs came into place and were then discontinued. The study, which is led by Qupanuaq and funded by Nunavut Tunngavik Incorporated (NTI), brings together researchers from Qupanuaq and the University of Colorado (Boulder), Toronto Metropolitan University, the University of Manitoba, Wilfrid Laurier University, and the University of Toronto. It is guided and supported by a Nunavut advisory committee. The impetus for this project was a direct request for research support from Qupanuaq, which wished to assess whether the grocery supports funded by ICFI effectively addressed community needs, and hoped to facilitate effective and timely advocacy for program reforms based on research findings.

The design of the grocery support research project was determined through an iterative, collaborative process in which advisory committee input informed the research team's drafting of design details. Specific research questions were developed, and plans for addressing each question were specified, through multiple iterations of the research team drafting of design elements and the advisory committee's response. This collaborative approach will continue throughout the life of the project, with the advisory committee meeting monthly to ensure that the evaluation efficiently builds on a broad base of existing resources and knowledge, is respectfully tailored to the local context, and supports advocacy and policy/program development initiatives.

The full research design includes key informant and family interviews, as well as analysis of data on purchases with grocery supports and outcome data (e.g. receipt of income supports, health outcomes, and school attendance). The introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program at different times across hamlets in Qikiqtaaluk results in a “natural experimental design” in which, at any point in time, we can compare outcomes in those communities that already implemented the Hamlet Food Voucher program to those that had not yet implemented the program. Family interview results and outcome analyses will be presented in subsequent reports on study findings.

In this technical report, we present preliminary findings from two elements of our larger, ongoing, study: 1) Interviews with key informants involved in developing and administering the grocery supports and Hamlet Food Voucher programs, and 2) Analysis of data on purchases made using individual-level, ICFI-funded grocery supports. The work presented here was approved by ethics boards at the University of Manitoba, the University of Colorado Boulder, and Toronto Metropolitan University, and conducted under a license granted by the Nunavut Research Institute.

Key informant interviews

We conducted interviews with 21 people living/working in 7 hamlets or working at the regional level (Qikiqtaaluk or Nunavut). Key informants included:

- Service coordinators, who help families access ICFI-funded supports and services;
- Service providers, such as health professionals or social workers;

- Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators and other Senior Administrative Officer (SAO) staff involved with the Hamlet Food Voucher programs;
- Grocery store managers/employees who helped administer ICFI funding at the retail level; and
- Staff members working in the Indigenous Services Canada (ISC) regional office responsible for administering the ICFI in Nunavut.

Key informants were recruited through email invitations to participate that were sent directly to all members of these categories identified in publicly available lists (e.g. lists of SAO offices and grocery store managers) and/or distributed by mediating contacts (e.g. NTI or an ISC manager). Informal, semi-structured interviews with those who responded were conducted over Zoom. Recordings were transcribed by AI, reviewed by a research assistant, and uploaded to MAXQDA. Data were initially categorized into broad codes (such as description of hamlet food voucher program, description of grocery supports, need for and impact of grocery supports/hamlet food vouchers, and gaps, challenges & innovations) and then sub-coded based on analysis of the larger themes. Emerging findings and points of tension were discussed with the full research team and advisory committee on a regular basis.

Analysis of grocery support purchase data

Receipts of purchases made by families in Qikiqtaaluk who received grocery supports were collected by ISC. The receipts were scanned, and a computer program recorded the date, price, quantity, location, and product description from each receipt on a spreadsheet that was made available to the research team. These data record the price of 302,006 distinct items purchased by recipients of individual ICFI grocery supports in 12 of 13 Qikiqtaaluk communities between mid-2020 and the end of 2024. We observe some prices for these products in most periods from 2022Q1 to 2024Q2 (the exception being the last three quarters of 2022, when we have very few receipts). These data allow us to examine both grocery prices and the types of purchases made using individual grocery supports.

To construct a price index, prices for each product and community were averaged within each quarter. We weighted each comparison of product prices within the community using the total quantity purchased in that community in our sample. This approximates the methodology used for the Consumer Price Index for food purchased from stores (CPI); it gives more weight to price increases for products purchased in greater quantities. Conceptually, this approach reflects the inflation rate for the goods purchased with ICFI vouchers.

Overall inflation: We report inflation rates in the period for which we have a large sample of products and communities: the beginning of 2022 to mid-2024. We break this down into inflation rates for the 2022Q1-2023Q2, the period *before* the introduction of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, and 2023Q2-2024Q2, the period during which most Qikiqtaaluk communities adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program. We also calculated inflation rates for specific food categories, within these time periods.

We compare these inflation rates to the CPI, which tracks changes in the cost of large baskets of food products over time.

Inflation for identical products: Any comparison of CPI inflation with inflation calculated using ICFI data is likely to be sensitive to the sample of products considered. Thus, for greater comparability, we matched 21 of the most popular products (in terms of number of units purchased) to products with the same description and size in Statistics Canada Table 18-10-0245-01; we adjusted for product dimensions, but we could not compare exact brands as these are not reported in the Statistics Canada data.

Inflation and price differences across communities: We used ICFI data to calculate separate inflation rates for the five communities with the largest sample of receipts in the dataset and inflation rates for specific food categories, within these time periods. In terms of price levels, the most recently available data that allows for comparison of a similarly broad set of products come from the 2017 Nunavut Price Survey (approximately 250 products, all retailers), and we report the estimated price gap between other communities and Iqaluit using the ICFI receipt data and the earlier 2017 survey.

Association of Hamlet Food Voucher program adoption with price increases: Finally, we conducted a more formal econometric analysis of ICFI Hamlet-level vouchers that used communities that had not yet adopted the Hamlet Food Voucher program as a comparison group. These analyses considered the adoption of Hamlet Food Vouchers alone and in models that controlled for prior use of individual-level ICFI grocery supports and the number of children in the community (which impacts the change in income when the program is adopted).

Limitations: A weakness of these data is the lack of representativeness and missing data for certain periods and communities. In practice, our analysis of inflation largely reflects the price of the products purchased most frequently with ICFI individual-level vouchers, in Northern stores, and in the communities where more individuals received these vouchers. The products are mostly food but include some clothing, household supplies, and other baby products. While these data are the most complete source of Qikiqtaaluk-specific food prices available to us, they have important limitations.

- Many important products are potentially excluded from the analysis because they were not purchased using ICFI individual-level food vouchers for a variety of reasons, including restrictions on what could be purchased. (As discussed in Chapter 4 of this report, these restrictions could differ across communities.)
- Some Qikiqtaaluk communities are not well represented. There are no data for Resolute Bay, and only 116 (0.04%) purchases from Grise Fiord and 1,171 (0.39%) from Kimmirut are observed in the data. Five communities make up over 70% of the sample (Iqaluit 23.5%, Kinngait 16.5%, Pangnirtung 12.8%, Igloodik 10.1%, Pond Inlet 9.9%).
- There are also very few transactions observed before 2022 (less than 0.26% of the sample), few transactions observed between March and December 2022 (1.1% of the sample), and very few transactions observed after June 2024 (only 0.72% of the sample). This means that

there is also little or no data on the price impacts of the Hamlet Food Voucher program in communities that converted to the Hamlet-level voucher program after 2023 (this includes Kimmirut, Sanikiluaq, Igloolik, Arctic Bay, Hall Beach, Kinngait, and Iqaluit).

- Our analysis also largely reflects prices at the Northern stores, as less than 1% of the receipts we received are from Co-ops.

Appendix 2: Investigator biographies

Vandna Sinha (PhD) is an Associate Research Professor in the School of Education at the University of Colorado, Boulder, and an adjunct professor in the School of Social Work at McGill University. Vandna uses community-engaged, mixed-methods, and transdisciplinary approaches to investigate questions of interest to her community partners. Much of her research and evaluation work focuses on access to equitable services for Indigenous children. She has conducted research related to Jordan's Principle, in partnership with Indigenous groups working at the national, regional, and local levels, since 2013.

Sindu Govindapillai (M.D.) is a pediatrician with public health training, living and working at Qikiqtani General Hospital in Iqaluit, Nunavut. She is the Director and co-founder of Qupanuaq, a non-profit based in Iqaluit that supports Inuit Child First Initiative (ICFI) service coordination, gap-filling programs, political advocacy, and impact evaluation. Sindu completed her medical and pediatric training at the University of Toronto and holds a Master of Public Health from Harvard University. She also holds an academic appointment in the Department of Pediatrics at the University of Ottawa. Her goal is to build a strong, locally driven evidence base for CFI interventions in Nunavut.

Nicholas Li (PhD) is an Associate Professor in the Department of Economics at Toronto Metropolitan University and is a member of the Centre for Studies in Food Security. He has extensive experience using econometric and statistical methodologies to estimate inflation and cost-of-living differences and to evaluate the impact of government policies. Since 2011 he has published numerous papers related to food security and inflation and since 2022 his research has focused on Canada's remote northern communities. He has multiple published papers and ongoing research projects analyzing programs like Nutrition North Canada and child benefits as well as retail competition and freight costs in the Northern Canadian context.

David Wheatley (PhD) is an Assistant Professor in Operations & Decisions Sciences at the Lazaridis School of Business and Economics, and a member of the Northern Sustainable Food Systems Research Group. He has been studying the impact of the Nutrition North Canada food subsidy and other systems to manage high food prices in Canada's North since 2021.

Jessica Penney (PhD) is a Nunatsiavut Inuk scholar raised in Iqaluit, Nunavut with family from Rigolet and Carbonear, Newfoundland and Labrador. Her research focuses on strengthening Inuit health, wellbeing and food sovereignty in the context of environmental issues in Inuit communities (such as environmental contaminants and climate change). Dr. Penney's PhD research was based at the University of Glasgow, and she held a Provost's Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Dalla Lana School of Public Health, University of Toronto. She is passionate about collaborative Inuit research methodologies and ethics and serves on Qaujigiartiit Health Research Centre's Ethics Katimajit and the National Inuit Ethics Review Committee.

Tracey Galloway (PhD) is a biological anthropologist and community health scholar at the University of Toronto Mississauga. Her research aims to reduce the burden of chronic disease among Indigenous people living in northern communities by removing existing barriers to health and food security. Tracey works alongside Indigenous leaders, Elders and other allies on projects that improve access to affordable food in northern communities. She is an active member of the International Union for Circumpolar Health. Her work is valued for its commitment to decolonizing principles and its support for Indigenous governance.

Mohammad Nuruzzaman Khan (PhD) is an Associate Professor of Social Work at the University of Manitoba. He studies economic justice, migration, and decolonization and teaches social policy, research methods, and non-profit management. Dr. Khan's research on economic justice focuses on the economic well-being, economic security and resilience of historically marginalized populations. He is currently studying the economic well-being of immigrants in Manitoba, a project funded by the SSHRC. Dr. Khan has been engaged in promoting social justice and anti-poverty advocacy, working closely with several community organizations, including the Social Planning Council, Winnipeg, Basic Income Manitoba, and Community Financial Counselling Services.

Josée G. Lavoie (PhD) is Dean of the College of Community and Global Health and Professor in the Department of Community Health Sciences at the University of Manitoba. Josée is of French-Québec ancestry and grew up in northern Québec isolated communities. Prior to undertaking her PhD, Josée spent a decade working for First Nation and Inuit managed primary health care systems. She has research expertise in health policy, financing, and contracting in health. She has been involved in the development of optimal models of contracting in health in Indigenous environments in Canada, Australia and New Zealand, in partnership with Indigenous organizations. She has also worked in Norway and Colombia.

Appendix 3: Components of welfare income by province/territory¹⁴⁴

Jurisdiction	Income component	Single parent, one child	Couple, two children
Northwest Territories	Basic social assistance	\$30,526	\$36,973
Northwest Territories	Additional social assistance	\$0	\$0
Northwest Territories	Federal child benefits	\$7,217	\$11,949
Northwest Territories	Territorial child benefits	\$815	\$1,059
Northwest Territories	Federal tax credits/benefits	\$1,184	\$1,430
Northwest Territories	Territorial tax credits/benefits	\$747	\$1,494
Northwest Territories	Total 2023 income	\$40,489	\$52,905
Nunavut	Basic social assistance	\$12,958	\$21,882
Nunavut	Additional social assistance	\$0	\$0
Nunavut	Federal child benefits	\$7,217	\$12,178
Nunavut	Territorial child benefits	\$339	\$677
Nunavut	Federal tax credits/benefits	\$1,184	\$1,430
Nunavut	Territorial tax credits/benefits	\$308	\$616
Nunavut	Total 2023 income	\$22,005	\$36,783
Quebec	Basic social assistance	\$11,076	\$21,387
Quebec	Additional social assistance	\$2,040	\$2,239
Quebec	Federal child benefits	\$7,217	\$12,178
Quebec	Provincial child benefits	\$3,758	\$5,794
Quebec	Federal tax credits/benefits	\$1,184	\$1,430
Quebec	Provincial tax credits/benefits	\$1,202	\$1,653
Quebec	Total 2023 income	\$26,476	\$44,680
Yukon	Basic social assistance	\$27,909	\$38,966
Yukon	Additional social assistance	\$3,536	\$6,793
Yukon	Federal child benefits	\$7,217	\$11,365
Yukon	Territorial child benefits	\$848	\$1,453
Yukon	Federal tax credits/benefits	\$1,184	\$1,430
Yukon	Territorial tax credits/benefits	\$692	\$1,384
Yukon	Total 2023 income	\$41,386	\$61,391

Appendix 4: Brief overview of application/implementation processes

Key informants shared detailed information about the development and implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program, demonstrating a complex scope of work that could carry a heavy administrative burden and could also have important impacts on program functioning.

The initial ‘group request’ proposals submitted to ISC to secure Hamlet Food Voucher program funding were fairly simple. Hamlets, supported by service coordinators, calculated costs based on expected expenditures of \$500 a month per Inuit child in the community for grocery supports, and \$250 additional for diapering items and formula for each Inuit child under the age of four. Most hamlets also applied for a dedicated position (or two) to run the program, setting the salary amount based on knowledge of what other hamlets included.

Once a proposal was approved, the hamlet was charged with recruiting and retaining a program coordinator and developing program guidelines and procedures before the voucher program could be implemented. Some hamlets had difficulty recruiting a program coordinator, and the SAO, or someone with an existing position within the SAO’s office added hamlet food voucher program responsibilities to their existing job descriptions. Others moved forward with the benefit of a dedicated staff person.

In either case, hamlets faced a series of key decisions that shaped the food voucher program for community residents:

- **Decisions around the timing of fund release** - As discussed in Chapter 4, a major decision in the design of the Hamlet Food Voucher Program involved weighing complex considerations to determine the timing of payments. Possibilities included releasing funds on a single day or on a rolling basis, in monthly payments or more frequently (e.g. every 2 weeks), and timing the fund release in relation to receipt of other benefits like the child tax. These decisions had implications for both the ability of families to stretch their funds across the month and the stability of food supply. As a result, Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators continued to adapt and adjust their policies after the program started.
- **Decisions around the modality of fund release.** Closely related to decisions around timing were decisions around the modality of fund release. Key informants spoke of significant variation in the modality of fund release across communities and noted that the administrative burden of the Hamlet Food Voucher program differed accordingly. In some communities, stores kept a log of expenditures in an on-site notebook, and this was updated with each purchase. In other places, stores provided dedicated gift cards that allowed for more efficient tracking and enabled transfer of balances in case of lost or stolen cards. Decisions around the modality of fund release were complicated by differences in store capacities and procedures: some stores took a couple of days to load funds onto their cards loaded, whereas others could do this within a day. Some stores could put only a limited amount (e.g. \$500) on their cards, so a family with 5 children had to manage 5 separate cards, whereas other stores could provide the same family with a single card with the full monthly amount loaded on it. In addition, stores differed in their requirements around payment: some required hamlets to deposit funds in advance, while others invoiced for payment later.

- **Restrictions on purchases** – Another key area of decision making, also discussed in Chapter 4, was restrictions on purchases. While many hamlets attempted to restrict purchases to healthy foods, we heard of at least one hamlet imposed no restrictions beyond those required by ISC (food purchases only). The decision to restrict purchases came with heavy administrative costs, including responsibilities to communicate restrictions to families and grocery stores, review receipts for restricted purchases, devise policies and practices for recouperation/repayment of funds spent on restricted items, and manage tensions that arose from attempts to control families' purchases. The modality of fund disbursement affected this aspect of administration, enabling Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators in some community to deduct the cost of restricted items from a families fund allocation while, in other communities, families were required to come to the hamlet to repay the cost of restricted items.

Once key parameters of the program were decided on, hamlets worked to facilitate program registration. In most communities, this was done in person, families came to a centralized location and filled out a form stating how many children they have and verifying their age and Inuit identity. In some places, like Iqaluit, registration online was also possible.

Once the program was initiated, significant administrative work was required to make the program run smoothly. hamlet food voucher coordinators/SAO office employees were charged with tracking children who aged out of ICFI (at age 19) and removing them from program. Similarly, they had to track the birthdays of young children and remove their access to funds for diapering supplies and formula when they turned four. Hamlet Food Voucher coordinators collaborated with grocery store managers/staff (who had to input and transfer funds to individual families' accounts) to ensure coordination around timing of fund release and track changes in accounts as people made purchases, moved between stores, or reported their gift cards lost/stolen. They also had responsibility for collection and storing of receipts, reviewing receipts for restricted purchases, updating accounts to deduct the cost of restricted purchases and/or communicating with families about repayment. In addition, they served as the primary contact for community members who had questions about the program and families who had concerns/complaints about program functioning.

Finally, people at the hamlet level were charged with troubleshooting and innovating to ensure the program functioned effectively, yielding maximum benefit for children and families. An example of the type of troubleshooting they had to do concerns the registration of children with caregivers in multiple homes (e.g. birth family and foster family). One Hamlet Food Voucher coordinator shared the experience of having caregivers from both a birth family and foster family attempt to register a child for the Hamlet Food Voucher program. She subsequently worked with Child and Family Services to arrange that they notify the Hamlet Food Voucher program when a child experienced a placement change (moving from birth family to foster family or vice versa). The information requested from Child and Family Services was simply who would now be responsible for feeding and diapering the child. Additional examples of innovations are discussed in Chapter 4 and summarized in the table below.

Areas of variation and innovation in implementation of the Hamlet Food Voucher program

Area of variation	Scope of variation	Issue being addressed
Timing of fund release	Rolling release, bi-weekly, monthly	Insufficient funds, challenges budgeting for the month, stability of local food supply.
Modality of fund release	Gift cards vs. store accounts	Efficiency of accounting
Restrictions on purchase	ISC restrictions on non-food items were often compounded by hamlet-level restrictions on junk food and sometimes additional items (e.g. coffee)	Promotion of healthy eating, and maintenance of the goal of providing food for children
Strategies for enforcing restrictions	Coordinator review of receipt, checker/manager sorting of items, repayment of funds, deduction from future funds	Compliance with rules around healthy food
Assignment to/transfer between grocery stores	Limited to one or two transfer per year, rotate between stores on a regular basis, switch on demand at the beginning of the month	Consumer choice
Collection/storage of receipt data	Collection of gift card statements, physical receipts, printed invoices, nothing	Accountability
Ideas for education	In store samples or recipes, workshops on healthy eating and budgeting, posters comparing ready-made-prices to home-made food prices	Promoting healthy & economical food choices

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